



SECRET

Maggie

KT MORRISON

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Contents

1. [Rave Cave](#)
2. [T-1000](#)
3. [Johnny vs. Kitana](#)
4. [Vaseline](#)
5. [Imitation](#)
6. [Liar](#)
7. [Secrets](#)

[Epilogue](#)

[Afterword](#)

[Other Books by KT Morrison](#)

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SECRET MAGGIE

A MAGGIE novella.

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Rave Cave

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 4TH

ON THE TUESDAY after their threesome Max had texted Cole and told him he wanted to start working out again. In their Freshman year they'd spent three nights a week in the gym. He'd liked it. Sport wasn't really his thing, he'd never even been on a team in high school. Played little league in Michigan, that was about it. Pee wee baseball for a few years and one summer tried out soccer. He was a decent runner. But lifting weights and spending time in the gym hadn't been his thing. Not until he went to college.

The time he'd spent there with Cole was fun. They attended religiously for a few months. Somewhere along the way he met the sweetest, most beautiful girl he'd ever talked to. Her name was Maggie Becker and they dated one time. Then they became friends. Then they were inseparable. It wasn't long before he was spending every night with her and it just seemed so natural. They were intimate. They were a couple. The gym fell to the wayside.

Cole still went regularly. He was on the lacrosse team, had scheduled sessions, but still popped in to do what he called 'hypertrophy'. Which just amounted to a lot of arm stuff and talking to girls.

"Dude, you really fell off," Cole laughed.

Max shushed him. His face must have been beet red, it felt like it might burst. He was struggling under a bench press. Arms shaking, just seven reps in and only 165lbs in his grip. He could see Cole's bare thighs up the inside

of the legs of his baggy shorts as he stood at the head of the bench ready to help him.

“You even *trane*, bro?” Cole laughed, trying to make *him* laugh, which was pretty mean, but Cole had his hands out to catch the bar. He was a good spotter.

Max made the rep, but he was done. He racked it, Cole’s hands gently guiding the bar back into its seat.

“Shit,” Max hissed as he sat up, feeling lightheaded suddenly and putting his elbows on his knees and hanging his head low. Three years ago he could bench press over 200lbs.

Cole squeezed his neck, said, “Don’t worry, Maxy. It’ll come back fast. Just keep showing up.”

Cole set himself onto the bench and he pressed the 165 ten easy times as a warm up. They were in the McKenna Weight Room, a blue rubber floored hall attached to the Franken & Sprock Fitness, Wellness, and Dance Center. Both sides were segmented with bright blue squat racks and Olympic platforms. The gym was busy tonight and this room was mostly populated with school athletes; all dudes, all of considerable size. The high ceilings were filled with the clank of metal and the thuds of rubber bumper plates thumping on the platforms.

Max stood, helped Cole take the fifteen pounds off the ends of the bar and slide on a big round 45lb plate instead. He took a spot at the head of the bench but didn’t put his hands out to spot. 225 was still a little light for Cole and Max looked around the gym while Cole stroked through another ten reps.

They removed the plates, added ten per side and Max lay down to press 155. He managed another seven reps. He sat up and shook his head, getting rid of a lightheadedness that came with the effort.

Cole said, “That’s good, Max. You’ll get back there.”

“Yeah, I know,” he said, inhaling deep and waiting for his vision to refocus.

Cole sat next to him. “Hey, so what’s with the sudden renewed interest in lifting weights?”

“I don’t know,” he said. “Well, no, I do. I mean, I want to look good for the wedding. I want to look fit on the honeymoon.”

“All right,” Cole said, his gaze going off across to the windows that looked out to a grassy field where a dozen students were walking to the

parking lot, backpacks over their shoulders and looking through their phones. “You’re in good shape, you know? You look fine.”

“Yeah. I could look better.”

Cole nodded, looked like he was trying to find the right way to say something. He said, “Just don’t think bad about yourself or anything...”

“I don’t.”

“Good. Good, I just...after the weekend, I don’t want you getting all *mental*.”

“Mental over what?”

He threw up both hands and laughed, “Never mind. It’s stupid. Let’s get back to work. Let’s do 250, okay?” He got off the bench and went around to the other side and worked plates off the bar to add his heavier weight.

Max helped him on the other side. Working his small plates off, adding a 45 and a 10 and a 2.5. He watched Cole across the bench. His good friend. A guy he trusted. He had heard his supportive words just now, but with their support came an apparent, probably unintended, condescension.

He and Max were both good-looking, Cole probably more so. Cole was bigger and stronger. That was all true. But Cole’s supportive words acknowledged that there was a difference between them and while it was so fucking true he hated that it was being addressed. It was stupid, but he’d always thought of himself as an equal to Cole. They just excelled in different areas. But now he’d seen what his best friend could do to a woman. Had watched his best friend work his very own fiancée into a frothing rabid frenzy, had her almost come in her panties without being touched. That was tremendous power. Now, it could have merely been the excitement of the initial coupling. The taboo. Perhaps he couldn’t do it again.

“Spot me,” Cole said.

Max shook himself from his reverie, nodded and got behind the bar. Cole gripped it, and Max took a good look at his friend’s hands; his skin, the shape of his fingernails. Those were another man’s hands and he had let those hands roam all over his girlfriend’s body. He’d put some of those fingers inside her vagina. And Maggie had liked it. This was all so wild and as wrong as it was, and despite the jarring terrible inertia his body felt when he thought about it, there was something weird and possibly evil twinkling inside him that wasn’t against it.

He'd never anticipated his sweet young future-bride being such an involved partner in his fantasy. She'd even surpassed him, he would say. He was following. He'd struck a match like a greedy little bed-wetting firebug now he stood gleefully, but heedlessly, clapping while her flames threatened to consume him. He'd even suffered a twinge of disappointment when Maggie had canceled on Jay again, two weeks in a row. It was for the better. They had Cole now, and Cole was a safer prospect.

Maggie was leaving to go home by herself on the weekend, back to Rhode Island to settle on her wedding dress. She would be leaving on Thursday afternoon, taking her classes off on Friday, her mother making her spend the long Columbus Day weekend at home. Maggie wasn't pleased, and given recent developments in their relationship, he wasn't sure how he was going to survive four days without seeing her. Her Thursday appointment with Jay, to draw him naked, had to be canceled. He'd reacted with calm and pragmatism. Interiorly, he'd jumped for joy. Then, deeper and darker, obversely, he cursed that he wouldn't get to see them together again. And, Maggie had even teased him that she would tell Jay her fiancé liked to watch, so Max wouldn't have to peer from the shadows like a creepy incubus, waiting for his lover's very dirty sloppy seconds.

Maggie had told him that Jay had an afternoon match and they both had classes they couldn't skip in the morning. Led Max to believe that there had been pronounced effort to find arrangements that would allow her pussy to be filled by his magnificent manhood. *She wanted it.* That burned in his belly like a coal. It seared painfully yet he wasn't sure that it also wasn't pleasure. Maggie distressed that Jay may lose interest in her but Max doubted it. He saw them together with his own eyes. Ultimately, they had Cole now. And while their union scared him in some ways, in others it was somehow fond and harmless.

As Cole pumped out his tenth rep and Max guided the bar back to its rest his phone buzzed in his pocket. "Hold on," he said to Cole who had bounced off the bench, invigorated by his success with 250, looking for more. Checked his phone and saw a text from Maggie.

Mags: Maxy! Blowing off studio tonight, not feeling it. Take me to dinner!!!

He thumbed the screen, took Maggie's words and scrolled them up and down, expelling nervous tension into them. He looked to Cole who was eying him from the bench with comical impatience. If they were going to be friends, the three of them, there could be no impedance to the relationship. A week ago he would have asked Cole to come with no hesitation. His friendship with this guy was so important.

He said, "Hey, man, Maggie's blowing off her painting tonight. Come grab dinner with us."

There was a look that passed Cole's rugged face. Something fond and distinctly appreciative. It was quick, a brief head shake, a shallow bowing of his brows. And a warmth in his eyes, too, an indescribable empressement that made Max feel his gesture was significant.

"For sure," he said softly and Max saw his Adam's apple work up and down.

"Cool," he said casually. A happy feeling tingled through him, seeing how this could work. They were all friends, what had been shared was fun, and they may do it again but it wouldn't become all that they were about.

He texted Maggie.

Maxy: sure thing, Cole's coming too

He felt really good. Good for Maggie too. He was showing her he could be cool about this. Maggie would see how big he was about this. This didn't bother him.

Then a dread hit him. He had to meet students at 7:30. He was giving three hours a week to Professor Klinger for Gov 201 as an Undergrad TA. He had to go over to Sperling Hall and give some one-on-one with a few scheduled students who needed some pointed instruction. He'd be there til almost 10 P.M. If the three of them had dinner he would be leaving them alone together. Fuck. Now it was all torn away. Big Man Max, Mister Confident felt a tremble in his guts, a chugging coming to his breath. Picturing himself leaving them to go off to Sperling and they were all cool and saying *Yeah, we'll just hang out*. And he'd have to say *Okay, have fun guys*. Have to leave them. Together. Couldn't be weird about it. Had to keep up the confident façade.

His phone vibrated in his hand as Cole clapped his hands and pointed him to the bench for his turn. He looked at his screen. Maggie had sent a

happy face.

“YOU COMING to the Rave Cave?”

Cole answered, “What’s that?”

“Oh my God, it’s gonna be the best,” the girl said, batting her eyes and cocking her head and embarking on a sales pitch to Cole.

She stood shorter than him, looking up into his eyes. She wore tight yoga pants and a lycra top with narrow shoulder straps. She was a sophomore, maybe, she looked very young. Blonde hair in a ponytail, it wagged while she talked. Big green expressive eyes, pouting her lips and arching her eyebrows as she talked, giving Cole every signal she could that she was available.

Max and Cole had been passing across the vacant Dance floor to the locker rooms and she, a girl named Ashton, had stopped them. Stopped Cole more accurately. The three of them stood at the base of the four-story rock climbing wall in stippled dove-grey, dotted with brightly colored hand holds and white chalky smudges of recent hand prints. Ashton wore a harness around her waist and between her legs, a chalk bag at the small of her narrow back. Her friend was bouldering, about ten feet up, moving from left to right. Max noted her darting envious glances over her shoulder to see who her friend was talking to below.

Ashton said, “We do the wall here,” she turned and waved a narrow toned arm towards the expanse of imitation cliff face, “it’s pitch black, but the route is marked with glow-in-the-dark handholds. We play music, there’s games...it’s a lot of fun...”

Cole shrugged, turned his nose up.

She laughed, said, “We wear helmets. With lights on them. You’re not afraid of the dark, are you?”

“No, I love the dark,” he smirked.

“Afraid of heights?”

“I’m not a climber,” he said.

“You have a good build for it,” she said, letting her eyes work over him.

“Yeah. Give me a call, I guess,” he said and made to continue.

“What’s your number?” she said to his back.

His hand worked in his shorts pocket and handed her his phone, said, “Put yours in my phone.”

She held his phone with two hands and her thumbs darted over the screen, then she tossed it back to him.

“Don’t come if you don’t want, but you’re going to miss out on a good time.” Now she smirked, and she was going to be dismissive too, flipping her tail as she turned briskly and left them to rejoin her friend.

Cole lead the way and Max caught up to him as they went through the double doors into the locker rooms.

“Dude, you’re not into that?” he said, giving a look back to see Ashton with a cocked hip, her back to them, chatting with her brunette friend as she jumped down off the wall.

“Huh, no...yeah, I am.”

“You totally blew her off.”

“Mm,” he hummed. “Rave Cave? Sounds dorky.”

“All right,” Max said, “but I don’t think she cared if you went up on the wall or not.”

They found their lockers in the busy change room, opened them up and got out their towels and toiletry bags. Max got undressed and kept his side to Cole. Cole turned his back to Max as he slipped his shirt away and then pulled his shorts and underwear off, threw them in a bag in his locker. Max watched his back. For the first time gave his good friend a real look instead of averting his eyes. Cole wrapped a towel around his waist and they went into the showers together.

The showers in the mens locker room were individual spigots set into the wall at about two arms length apart. It was busy but they were able to find two spigots together. Max got his water to temperature and hung his towel up on the wall, looking out the side of his eyes at Cole. Saw his towel come off and hang on the hook by his own spigot. He was aware of the swinging between Cole’s legs.

Cole put his face into the spray, his hands coming up and rubbing at his cheeks and brushing his long thick hair back. The water splashed off him and ran down his naked body.

Max unabashedly looked at him now. Looked at him through a woman’s eyes—Maggie’s eyes—seeing him as more than just his good friend. Seeing him how a lustful woman—again his Maggie—might see him. He noted his lustrous skin, his light chest hair and trail down to his belly button and

lower. Cole's waist was narrow, his shoulders broad and his arms muscular. Max's sweet Maggie had felt it all. Seen it all bare and been intimate with him.

His balls were big and low hanging, his sleepy flaccid cock was noticeably thick but not truly indicative of the massive girth he grew to when he was aroused. Maggie had sucked that thing. She'd had it inside her. Her vagina, her ass. She'd tasted his come. Cole had emptied those big balls inside her pussy too. His Maggie had enjoyed this guy's beautiful body and his fantastic sex equipment.

Shit. Max was growing. His cock had jumped up to stick almost straight out. Not hard but definitely suspect looking to anyone else who might see it. Fuck. He looked away, tried to think of anything but Maggie and Cole together.

It had been so exciting. He'd been so tense in the moment that he wasn't enjoying it as much as he was now in retrospect. Now that four days had passed, the sharpness had been worn away and it seemed like the lubricious thrill was remaining.

He thought about school. Put his head under the spray and did his best to hide the swelling between his legs.

"I JUST CAN'T BELIEVE you've never been rock climbing."

"I know. I seem like a guy who might have been rock climbing," Max said.

"You do. I went one time, but it wasn't planned. Bunch of my bros went to Chauncey Peak in high school and we were camping. Met some girls from Yale Mountaineering and tagged along with them. They took us to Traprock Ridge and showed us what they could do. I tried it but I was just there to get laid."

"Did you? Get? ..."

Max heard three flat-footed slaps of thin rubber-soled shoes on the sidewalk and then his body was slammed with a light giggling monkey. Legs shot around his hips, thin arms clung to him and he stumbled forward half a dozen steps to avoid falling over.

"Get what?" the sweet voice said in his ear. Two hands were crossed over in front of him, his engagement diamond on her ring finger.

"Get nothing," he said, "never mind." He grabbed her thighs where they clung at his hips and he hoisted her higher.

When Cole skipped a few steps and caught up with them, she said to him, "Well, how did he do? He grow any muscles?"

Max said, "Not yet."

Maggie bit his earlobe and her breath tickled his ear and made him jump and squirm. She gripped him tightly so she wouldn't be thrown off and it got her laughing.

“He did well, but I think he's mad because he wasn't as strong as he used to be.”

“Aw, Maxy,” she said, “you're plenty strong.”

He hitched his step and pulled on her thighs again to keep her from slumping. They were walking down the Main Street of Farmingham village on their way to dinner at Altieri's. It was October now, and while the fiery leaves still clung to the trees the sky was gray and it was getting dark earlier. The streetlights had flickered on and buzzed while throwing off their amber corona into the burgeoning dusk.

Maggie squeezed his neck tight and she kissed his neck. “Your muscles sore yet?”

“I'm fine,” he said.

“You going to be sore tomorrow?”

Cole said, “He's going to be sore tomorrow. He put out a max effort.”

Maggie laughed loudly in his ear. “That's his new nickname—Max Effort. We should get him some business cards.”

“Excuse me for wanting to look good in our wedding pictures.”

“You look good *now*, Maxy. I love your body.”

Cole said, “You can lift all the weights you want, you're still going to pale against your bride, buddy.”

“That's the point,” Max grumbled comically for them. “I at least want to look like I belong there.”

Cole laughed. “Nah, you're wedding pictures are going to look like a kidnapping.”

Max hitched Maggie up again as her crotch slipped down to his rump. She hopped off and got behind Cole. Max watched her weave her arms around his neck, reaching up while he bent forward and she leap-frogged onto his back. Cole got her onto him and she clung comfortably, one hand running her untied hair back off her face.

Cole had one hand under her calf, her two legs were crossed over one another at his waist. She wore khaki chinos, slim fit, rainbow-striped socks under her black leather loafers with folded over kilties and dancing tassels. Max watched how Cole's big hand held her slim leg, his thumb stroking the ridge of her shin.

“Wow, am I hungry,” she laughed. “What are you getting me?” she said, and she hugged her cheek to the back of Cole's neck then extended her hand to Max, wanting him to take it. He worked closer to the two of them, got his

fingers between hers and held her hand against his shoulder as the three of them walked together.

“What do you want?” he said.

“I want...a pepperoni pizza...two beers, uh, fudge brownie with ice cream...”

“Where does little Maggie put it all?” Cole laughed.

Maggie said, “Brain power. My brain burns a lot of calories.”

“Mine doesn’t,” Cole said, “mine stays mostly in neutral.”

They sauntered on in the cool colorless night until they came to the warm light spilling from Altieri's out onto the sidewalk. They could see one lone empty table in the busy restaurant and it was right at the front window that looked out to the street.

“Oh shit, come on quick,” Cole said. He pointed with his chin for Max to get the door so he could carry Maggie into the restaurant on his back. Max got the door, opened it, and Cole dipped low as he went so Maggie wouldn’t bump her head. Max dodged ahead and got the door on the other side of the vestibule and they went to the table. They claimed their spot ahead of two rushing sophomores who surrendered it to them—to Cole—without objection and Cole backed Maggie onto one of the high chairs.

“Thank you, baby,” Maggie said, and she pulled her shoulders out of her jacket and then draped it behind her over the crest rail of the chair she was sitting on. Max sat across from Cole and Maggie was between them facing out onto the street.

Maggie’s familiarity with Cole was nothing new, but seeing it now in the light of what had happened this last weekend it did appear heightened or amplified. Seeing her clinging to his back, calling him *baby*, pressing her cheek to his neck... These were all things that in this new territory they were exploring poked and jabbed at his heart. It wasn't fun to see, but he couldn't deny the little jewels of jealous pleasure that came with them.

“What made you skip your painting?” Cole asked.

“I don't know. I just wasn't feeling it. I was sitting there...staring at a blank canvas.” She shrugged, held her shoulders high, raised her eyebrows.

The two of them held eye contact. Max watched it with bated breath. His two best friends, eyes leveled at one another, the communication there—something that neither one of them was sure of and Max sure as hell wasn't sure of, but it definitely felt like he might not be a part of it. Then there was a nervous laugh and everyone felt a bit awkward. Cole and Max

leaned back, shrugged off their jackets, and they all looked through their menus though they already knew what they would order. One of the waitresses they knew well, Jenny, came along, laughing with them and then making a joke with Cole. She was a cute little Vermont girl, fresh-faced and well-fed, and very friendly. They ordered and when she left the uncomfortable silence resumed.

There was something between all of them and they were conscious of it. They were also all very aware that it was something that should be addressed, but none of the three of them were willing to be the first one to mention it. So they sat across from each other, their eyes darting from chests to hands to drink menus to napkins, and they did everything *but* talk about what had happened.

Max opened his mouth as if to say something but he hesitated and sat there with his mouth open, the two of them looking at him. Thankfully his phone, sitting on the paper napkin placemat, vibrated against the wood table. He was instantly grateful. Looked down to his phone, it was sitting face up, saw the familiar family photo portrait.

“Hey, it's my dad,” he said quietly to the table, his eyes turned down. He picked up his phone and answered, a relieved smile on his face, showing it to his two friends who were watching him. The restaurant was lively and his father's connection was quiet and he strained to hear his dad.

“What was that, Dad?” he said, putting a finger up and into his other ear.

“I said, what's up, Maxy?” The tinny voice grew louder.

Maggie bubbled next to him, “Say Hi for me, Max.” His dad was already on to the next sentence and now he couldn't hear that. He winced and shushed Maggie with his palm, angled away to hear him better.

“Sorry, Dad, I couldn't hear you.”

As his dad spoke Maggie was at his shoulder, off her high chair, loafers on the floor and leaning against Max. “Hi, Mr. Milton,” she sang over his shoulder and into his phone.

Max pulled away again. His Dad said, “Is that my Maggie?”

“Yes, Pop,” he said.

“Hey, Mags,” his dad yelled into the phone.

“He says Hi,” Max told Maggie dryly, two fingers over the phone's mic.

His dad said, “So how was the big weekend, kid? You never called...”

“Yeah, sorry, Dad, I forgot.” He stepped down off the high chair and swam his shoulders through the tight crowd, out to the maître d’s booth and then into the vestibule. A line had formed already and the overflow was backed up, so he passed out to the fresh fall air and on to the street.

“What was the church like?” his dad asked.

“Oh you know,” he said. “It was... Like, it’s Rhode Island. It was this wooden church, painted white. Right by the water...”

“Yeah, yeah...you like it?”

“Oh yeah, I like it a lot, Pop.”

It was cold out on the street now, the sun down, the gray gone and somehow a chilling blue had seeped into everything. Maggie and Cole sat together in the center front window, the letters of Altieri’s in gold arced above their heads. Maggie was laughing and smiling, cocking her head to Cole as they talked, doing it in an affectionate way. She laughed loud, a guffaw, her little hand gripped Cole’s wrist.

“And how was the T-1000?”

“Whats that?”

“The T-1000. Martin. That’s his designation at the factory, isn’t it?”

“Ha, ha, Dad. He was fine.”

“The Terminator...” his dad said in a chilling monster movie voice, thick with a Schwarzenegger-esque accent. His dad laughed, his mom laughing in the background too, then said, “Tell me about the reception...”

Max told him about the Poirot, about the menu. His dad got a kick out of the extravagance. He wanted Max to guess how much they were going to spend. Max had no idea, he told him. He could picture his Dad right now, slippers with the open back, legs splayed on his recliner. His mom would be sitting with the TV paused, her feet tucked under her, a plaid pillow clutched to her stomach, watching her husband mirthfully.

Inside the restaurant, Maggie was telling Cole a story now, sitting up straight, her face earnest, her eyebrows dancing with enthusiasm. She would flick her hair back, and smile warmly while it was his turn to speak. She’d even bite her lip and play with her earring. It was killing him. He wanted to know what they were talking about. Wanted to be in there with them.

When he was telling his dad about the campfire and the beach and Maggie’s brother Ken and about Stanford Med, he saw at last the waitress coming with their order and he told his dad he had to go.

“All right, kiddo. Call me later in the week. You might even think about calling twice a week, maybe chatting your mom up. She misses—”

“Okay, Pop, sorry, I will...really, I gotta split.”

“Fine, fine, Maxy boy. Give my love to that little princess of yours, tell her we love her...”

“I will, Dad.”

“Love you, kid.”

“Love you too, Pop. Tell Mom I love her.”

He disconnected the call and pressed his phone to his chest. Watched the two of them drawing pieces of pizza up high, sagging cambered strings of bright mozzarella clinging to the stainless platter. They looked happy. They looked content with each other’s company. He loved both of them. Hated the dagger in his heart when he thought of them doing things without him. But they had always done things together. Maggie and Cole were friends. They would be alone. Now though, it was with the benefit of having an intimate exchange. One both of them liked very much. They had fucked and they’d both been really good with each other.

He sighed. It would be tonight. They would be alone tonight without him. He looked at his watch. He had twenty-five minutes for dinner then he had to go to...

MAGGIE PUSHED HER PLATE AWAY. They always thought she ate a lot but she really only had two pieces of pizza and the brownie wasn’t that big. Big enough that she had a bit of a sugar sizzle humming through her central nervous system. She was full but she wasn’t stuffed. Max pushed his empty plate away and he looked like he was going to burst. His face had gone red like a tomato.

“Ah, I don’t now why I go to the gym, it just makes me eat more,” he complained, a hand on his stretched stomach.

Cole said, “You’ll burn some calories tomorrow. I’ll put you through a leg day.”

“Tomorrow?”

Max’s alarm on his phone softly chimed a sound of rising digital bubbles. His stuffed face transformed to pain.

She knew what that expression meant. He knew he'd be leaving them now to go to Sperling for his TA students. She also knew that he wouldn't say anything, wouldn't try and prevent her and Cole from hanging out. And while he would keep it bottled in she also knew that his pain was pressing up against his inner lining like the pizza and beer and brownies were pressing up against the inside of his stomach. Her poor Max was being tortured. His heart, his belly, and ultimately his cock and balls. That's where all his feelings were deriving from these days. Her dirty little Max and his desires. He was as dirty as she was. His suffering was some masochistic form of pleasure. It had to be. How would she work with him? What made him tick?

His narrow mouth worked around, his eyes lowered, pensive, lost in tortured thought. At last he said, "I guess I better get going."

She didn't answer him, watched him. Didn't look at Cole either. He didn't say anything. Max got his wallet out and he leafed through cash, flicked out enough bills to cover the meal for all three of them and a tip for Jenny.

Cole said, "Hey thanks, man. I'll get next time."

"Yeah," Max said idly, folding up his wallet and tucking it back in his pocket. He fumbled his phone, checked the screen nervously one more time, looked to Cole then back to Maggie. He sniffed. "I'm going to be done around ten o'clock. You guys...you know where you're going to be?"

Cole shrugged, looked to Maggie. "You free?" he asked her.

"Yeah." She turned to Max then. She shrugged to him now, said, "I don't know. Cole and I will hang out."

Max nodded.

She let him off the hook, let him have three thick viscous heartbeats, slowed like sludge with dread. She said, "Come by my room when you're done?"

"You'll be there?" he said, a brightness in his eyes.

"Probably," she said. Then, "Text me."

His expression resumed a flat blankness. "Okay," he said.

He kissed her then, she turned his cheek to him. He held her hand and she kissed his mouth. His eyes trembled with all he wanted to say, but his mouth stayed closed. Maybe he wanted to appear that he trusted her. She wanted him to trust her. It was distinctly possible however that he loved the danger. He was thrilled by her hanging out with Cole after what they'd

done. If she asked him if this was okay he'd say No, but if she didn't he'd twist and turn not knowing what they were doing without him, and strangely—this was the weird part—he would get off on it.

Max tapped the edge of his phone on the table a few times. “Yeah, okay. I’ll...I’ll see you guys later.”

“Bye, Maxy,” she said.

“Bye, buddy,” Cole said.

Max turned and he left without looking back. His journey took him back to campus, so he didn't pass by the window.

Cole leaned back, absently looking to see if he could catch a glimpse of him.

“Want another pitcher?” she asked Cole.

He worked his hands together, looked her over, his expression as blank as Max's. A nod began. He said, “Yeah, let's have some more.”

She waved Jenny over, pushed Max's money to her, said, “But we're going to order another pitcher.”

Jenny went off, weaving happily through the noisy crowd. Cole said, “You feel like some Xbox?”

“Yeah, I do,” she said, showing him her teeth in a genuine friendly smile.

The pitcher came and Cole poured, and in fifteen minutes they had it lowered to suds on its plastic bottom. They talked about school and they talked about Max, and Cole made light furtive jokes about people they knew hanging out in the restaurant.

Whatever tension Cole had felt about the evening it was gone by the time they'd reached the bottom of the jug of Miller. Cole threw down a twenty and grabbed his jacket and said, *Let's go...*

They walked together and she noted a stiffness still between them. It did feel funny and awkward to be alone with him. He was her good friend and she wanted things to be the way they were last week. But there was a part of her enjoying this weird new thing too. It was fun to be his friend, but it was also fun to be a little anxious. To wonder when they were going to be intimate next. If there would be a *next*. She wanted it to happen, but there was no guarantee that it would. This felt distinctly like a date right now. It had that same exciting tension. She'd only ever dated her Maxy boy. But this was what it was like in those early days with her fiancé, before he was her fiancé. Wondering what he felt about her. Wondering if he liked her.

Wondering if they would get frisky. Did he like her body? Did she perform well for him? Did he want to have sex again? Those were exciting times. The most exciting in her life.

This was strange territory with Cole. They were friends, now had been naked, engaged in particularly graphic sex. Had a threesome. It was a Wednesday night and not one of the three of them had the sense to draw up a set of rules. She belonged to Max. Maybe there were no rules drawn up though, because there were no rules... Common sense should dictate, right? Don't fuck Cole tonight, Maggie. That was obvious. Max would be upset. Not *I'm leaving you it's over upset*, but more like genuine hurt. She didn't want him to hurt but she was aware that part of her Max was curious about hurt.

So she kept it light and forced a pleasant last-week's-Maggie smile on her face and decided they would be friends tonight like they had always been. Her and her buddy Cole would play Xbox, they would have a drink. It would be casual and fun just like it always was and she wouldn't fuck him. She wanted to, could feel that tightening inside her, knowing what it would be like, but that was enough. She knew what Cole was like but she was Max's girl. She would fuck Cole again, knew it, but it would be an organized inclusive affair that wouldn't hurt her fiancé.

When they got to Samuelson they heard raucous cheering coming up from the lower level. She could see sneakered feet, a dozen sets or more, all aimed, toes forward, to where the TV would be. The ping-pong table was inactive and littered with pop cans and solo cups. There was a gathering down there and it looked like it was standing room only.

"Ah shit," Cole said as they stood at the top of the short wide flight of stairs.

"What is it?"

"I forgot. Ole Miss and Alabama."

"Football?"

"Yeah."

A roar built up in the residents gathered below, feet went to toes, bodies leaned forward, there was a chant from some, a *Yes...yes...yes...* repeated as a play developed on the big screen that the Xbox was attached to. It culminated in a roar as there was a touchdown or a sack or whatever excited guys who watched college football.

Cole said, "Hey, come up to my room."

As the cheers dragged on from below she watched Cole's face. Tried to read it. There was a wariness in his eyes and she imagined hers showed it to him as well. They stared at each other a long moment, put nothing into words. There was clapping echoing up from the rec room, banter, and someone whooped. She bit her lip.

"Yeah. Okay," she said.

Cole cocked his head, she'd said Yes already but he acknowledged the reluctance, said, "My roommate got a TV last week. He has an Xbox too."

She lightened, some of the taboo washed off her agreement. Then a funny feeling, wondering if maybe he wasn't interested in her sexually anyway. She frowned. She thought he was. Stifled her own laugh—realizing she really wanted him to be.

"Let's go," she said, gesturing with a hand to the flight of stairs twenty feet down the hall that would lead them up to his dorm room. Cole smiled too now, and there seemed to be a rapprochement here. A bridging of two halves that used to come together quite nicely when they were just friends. She would hate to lose that.

Johnny vs. Kitana

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 4TH

COLE LED the way and she followed. She was noticeably quiet, lost in thought about all the protocol when a woman who was engaged was spending time in the private room of another man. She shook her head, tried to keep herself away from the salacious, wanted to say something, but the best she could come up with was, “What games does he have?”

Cole spoke over his shoulder, said, “I don’t know. I never play with him.”

“Oh,” she said. Then back to a self-conscious quiet, two canines pinching a lump of her slippery inner lining just below her bottom lip, making it tangy.

They climbed to the third floor, turned right, and made their way to his room. She saw Caitlin who she attended Literature study group with and she felt a tingle of fear. Like she’d been caught sneaking around. But Caitlin just said *Hi, Maggie, Hi Cole* as she passed, her face lit with a big genuine smile. Maggie’s heart was pounding. Where did this guilt come from? Caitlin knew she was friends with Cole, she’d seen them together before. Even on this floor...even near his dorm room.

Cole went ahead of her into his room. Past his shoulder she could see that his roommate was sitting up on his bed with his back up against the wall, reading a book.

“Satinder, buddy...” Cole boomed.

“Hey, Cole,” he said meekly, putting his textbook down on his thighs.

“Hey Satinder,” Maggie said to him.

“Hi Maggie. How’s Max?”

“He’s good. We all just had dinner together.”

Cole sat on Satinder’s bed, looked over his shoulder at him. Satinder looked at Cole with an eager urge to please. He had a boy-crush on Cole. That’s how she would describe it. He would love to please Cole, just to be considered part of his world. Cole said, “Dude, we were going to play Xbox, me and Maggie, we get here and the Ole Miss Alabama game has the rec all jammed up.”

“Oh hey,” he said. “You can...you want to play here?” He sat straighter, inching himself closer to the edge of the bed.

“Yeah, man, that’d be great. You set it up for us?”

“Sure,” Satinder said, and he got his sock feet on the floor and dropped to his knees, walked to the mid-size flat screen near the foot of his bed on his side of the room. Satinder worked buttons and brought out controllers. Cole smiled to Maggie. She sat on Cole’s bed across from them.

“What do you want to play?” Satinder said.

“I don’t know. What do you got? Something two-player. Something head-to-head.”

“Mortal Kombat X?”

“Perfect,” Cole said, looking to Maggie. “I will kick the living shit out of her,” he said, looking in her eyes.

As Satinder got it set up and the screen came to life with the menu for the game Cole said, “You got somewhere quiet you want to go? It’s going to get noisy in here, I don’t want to disturb you.”

“Yeah,” he said, his already sad eyes drooping a little in the corners.

“Cool man. Cool.” He got up and came to his own bed and sat next to Maggie, on the side nearer his pillows. As Satinder put his things together and slipped his books and laptop into his knapsack Cole opened the drawer of his bedside stand. A flash of silver winked in his hands as he drew out a flat metal flask the size of a slim paperback. “Got this on Monday,” he said.

“A hip flask?” she said.

“Have fun,” Satinder said as he backed out of the room with his hand on the door lever.

“Thanks, Satinder,” she said to him as he closed the door.

“Thanks a lot, buddy,” Cole called after him. He unscrewed the cap and took a swig.

“What is it?” she asked.

“Whisky,” he said, and swiped his mouth with the back of his hand. He held the flask out to her.

She took it, sniffed the contents. It was fierce. She sipped it, and it burned her throat going down. She made to talk, winced as a fire erupted from within her. She lowered her head. “Oh shit, that’s terrible,” she laughed.

“Not as good as what your dad buys, I’m sure, but it’s not Thunderbird.”

“Oh wow,” she said, fanning her face.

“Have another sip,” he said, urging the flask to her mouth. “It gets easier.”

“It does?”

“It does. I swear.”

She took another sip and held it in her mouth. No burn, cool against her cheeks. She swallowed. The fire returned. “Ouch,” she giggled.

Cole took his flask from her and tipped a healthy gulp of his own, closed it up and lay it on his bed.

“Come on,” he said, and he left the bed and set himself in front of the TV, sitting cross-legged on the floor. He pat the space next to him. She hesitated on the bed, sitting with her elbows dug into her thighs. Cole stayed expectant yet confident, still patting the space next to him. He had a black lacrosse sweatshirt, grey cotton pants and chukkas. He looked very good to her. His unshaved face and his strong features, then that thick but lustrous blonde hair. She sighed.

“What?” he laughed.

She said, “Should we...be alone in your room?”

His smile didn’t falter. He said, “Would you have come to my room last week?”

“Yes.”

“So, Maggie, don’t let that be ruined.”

“I don’t want it to be ruined.”

“It’s something in our control. Just don’t think about it.”

“Sure,” she said. “Okay.” It was a warm feeling he gave her but she couldn’t help wonder what it would take to bring out that man that had dominated her on the day of her wedding planning. The bold one who stood on the altar with her where she was to be married and told her to go and take her panties off and put them in his pocket.

“Fuck it, right,” she said. She got down on the floor next to him and she sat cross-legged, pulled her Weejuns off and slid them to the edge of the wall. Cole worked through the menus, picked a two-player head to head challenge and started scrolling through characters looking at their digital mugshots and settling on whom he would assume to engage her in combat.

He landed on Kitana and selected her without hesitation.

“So sad,” she said.

“Why?”

“Your culture’s propensity to appropriate mine with such easy vigor.”

Cole laughed, said, “Hey, Maggie, you can pick the cool white dude if you want. I’d be honored not offended.”

“Oh, I am,” she said, settling on Johnny Cage and locking her choice in. “I’m going to kick your skinny Japanese ass, hold you down and make you slap yourself in the face with your dumb fans.”

“They’re called sensu, whitey.”

She laughed and threw her head back, feeling like it was all falling back in place.

“You ready?” he asked her.

She turned to him and said, “Hey, what did you think of my parents?”

“They were nice,” he said, a smirk tugging one corner of his mouth.

“What did you think of my father? ...Really think?”

“Your dad...seems like a no-nonsense asshole, if you don’t mind me saying. But like, he cuts throats too. He’s not just hard-line discipline, he’s got a boner for success and winning.”

“Not bad. Pretty close,” she said. “Actually, very close, like bullseye-close,” she murmured to the side. “And, what about my mother?”

“Your mom is so hot.”

She was stunned. She looked at his profile as his gaze was fixed to the hopping readied fighters on the screen. He wasn’t joking. “What? ...She’s hot?”

“Fuck, yes,” he said with enthusiasm.

She shook her head, said, “She’s so stern looking.”

“I like that,” he laughed. “She looks like she might like it real rough.”

Her jaw dropped. She had never, ever, ever in her life heard anything like that. No one had dared refer to her mother in that manner. She never thought of her mother like that.

Cole turned and his expression had fallen, his eyes tinged with a worry. "What? ...Oh, that make you mad? Sorry, Maggie...was that inappropriate?"

She couldn't stop herself. She burst out in laughter. Honest exuberant joy exploding from her at that crazy thought. The more she thought of it the more it leapt from her. Her eyes went wet with tears. She pictured her mother in the hallway at The Poirot, pressed against the wall with Cole looming over her, sticking his hand down her panties and touching her quite assuredly very-hairy snatch. She laughed harder. Pictured her mother powerless against him, nothing mean to say to him, nothing to use against him as he slid a finger inside her. A different Cole, not the boy-Cole next to her now, not the student—the man with the tie, the confident one who'd made her sex-sweat leak down her legs. Now guffaws came. She was aware of Cole watching her and laughing along now too but her vision was so warbled with tears she couldn't make him out. Pictured her mother in the conservatory taking it up the ass with Cole's big fat cock. Pictured her tight mouth forming O shapes as he pummeled her, heard imaginary gasps and cries tinged with her Chinese voice. Now she fell back on the floor, laughing so hard she couldn't breathe, she fanned her face and tried gulping for air. "Oh, oh my God," she managed, then was racked with more laughter. She heard Cole laughing too, a good honest belly laugh, enjoying that he'd got her so bad with such a ludicrous thought.

When it subsided she wiped her tears away, her finger digging into the hollows of her eyes and her belly still quivering with humorous aftershocks.

Cole said, "You're crazy."

His voice was close, very close and she blinked away the wet and moved her hands from her face. He was above her, his masculine face over hers. She giggled, "I'm picturing it. Oh shit." Her body was seized with more laughter, her stomach sore now.

Cole said, "Maggie's got the giggles."

"I do," she said, looking up into his eyes. They weren't face to face, more side to side. His eyes darted over hers.

He put a hand on her cheek, his thumb brushing away a wet streak that she felt plop into her ear canal. He said, "Max is so lucky. You're going to be as beautiful as her when you're fifty. Just as beautiful as you are now."

She whispered, "You think I'm beautiful?"

"Inside and out."

A tremble passed through her jaw and she was sure it was visible. He looked into her eyes and she didn't look away. This was way too bad. This wasn't dirty this was just plain bad. A smile pulled her cheeks up, she laughed again. She said, "You ready to get your ass kicked?"

"You sound confident."

She sat up, still wiping her face and sniffing. The controller was in her lap and she scooped it out. "Oh I am."

He watched her from the side, she could sense a confident smile on him, see it in his posture. He said, "Stakes then?"

"Stakes? Like what?"

He shrugged but his face was still turned to her. "I don't know... Strip Mortal Kombat?"

She chuckled, turned to him, said, "Strip Mortal Kombat?"

"One clothing item per round." He smirked and cocked an eyebrow.

"I don't know..."

"It's innocent." His head was cocked, his smirk morphing to a devious smile that narrowed his eyes.

She inhaled. Exhaled. "Fine. I'm going to win anyway."

"Then you don't mind a challenge reward..."

She turned to face him again. "Reward?"

"Like a dare. Loser performs a dare."

"What is this...high school? Not that I played strip anything in high school...it just seems a little juvenile."

"It's fun. Can't have fun when you're twenty? Believe me, we're not that mature. We're about to play strip Xbox..."

She laughed, "That was your idea!"

"You like it. Dare me..."

She sucked her lower lip into her mouth, smiled, bit it. This was bad but it was fun. Maybe something like this would be somewhere in the middle. Fun and friendly and playful but an acceptable level of nudity and hanky-panky. They were friends, they had been intimate, there was nothing between them other than friendship, and quite frankly the idea of playing strip games with him right now was so incredibly exciting. She didn't want to be seen naked by him...and that was startlingly arousing. Put a fear in her like she imagined maybe Max would get. Knowing she didn't want to be revealed to him in these unflattering dorm room lights but the naughtiness of it so alluring she wanted to submit to his dumb game. And if she won,

she would see him naked. And she liked that. That was just as exciting. Taboo in its way but somehow even more prominent. She hummed, let her lip plop out, said, "When I win, you'll be naked. So...you have to streak. Like from here, across this floor, down the stairs, across the fourth floor, up the stairs back here." She drew the imaginary route in the air with her forefinger for him.

"Sweet," he said.

"Sweet? You better take this seriously. What's your dare?"

"Uh...mine's for the greater good."

"What?"

He said, "You stiffened up on me..."

She frowned, her head angling back. "When?"

"In the music room."

Now she bristled. A flush of warmth worked through her from her head, her ears, across her face and down her neck to her collar. "Stiffened? Stiffened how?"

"Anal," he said casually

She tilted her head back, her mouth open like she was laughing but she was silent. She laughed quietly. "Cole, your..." she leaned closer and whispered, "your dick is really thick."

"You can take it. I want you to relax. So, my dare...you have to lay with me and let yourself relax on it."

"No, we can't do that. What about Max? We can't have sex without him. We can't..."

His eyebrows went up in supportive calm, he said, "I think you tightened up because Max was there. We can't make it work when he's making you tense. I'm not saying we have anal sex, honestly. I just want you to...accommodate me. Get used to me."

"Why?" she laughed, the laugh becoming a girlish giggle.

"I can do amazing things to you, to your ass. I don't want you to miss it." That confident narrow-eyed smile was back.

She imagined future couplings. "We're not having sex?" she asked with speculative expression, looking for confirmation.

"I swear. I'm training you."

She squinted, said, "Breaking me in?"

"You've got a tight virgin asshole."

"You're gross."

“You don’t think I’m gross.”

“No,” she laughed, looking at his merry but serious face. She sighed, looked up at the ceiling, looked down at Johnny Cage, hopping from foot to foot in anticipation of the oncoming melee. “Okay. No sex though.”

“Look at your face, you’re blushing. You’re thinking about losing aren’t you?” he sang in mock intimidation, picking up his controller.

“Fuck off,” she giggled. She shot up, went to his dresser and looked at her reflection in his mirror. Her face had red fever splotches, “I *am* blushing,” she laughed and she pat her own cheeks. She turned and she put her butt on his dresser, lay her hands over its edge. “We have to tell Max, Cole.”

“If you want. It’s up to you,” he said, his eyes honest and expressive.

“We have to tell him,” she said.

THEY TOOK FIVE GAMES APIECE, alternating win after loss over their first ten match-ups. Each had removed five items of clothing.

Maggie had tried to put her shoes back on before they started but Cole wouldn't let her. He took one out of her hands, peeled one off her foot that she'd managed to slip on. Then, before they began, she made him take off his shoes too.

Maggie lost the first game and Cole taunted he would win in eight straight, and he would soon see her naked. He said it to frighten her, to shake her game. She peeled off one sock. She won the next and he took off one sock. Then, two more matches they both wound up bare foot. The next loss Maggie removed her black V-neck cashmere sweater, folded it and tossed it onto the chair with Cole's bag and books taking up the flat of the seat. Next, Cole removed his sweatshirt. Then Maggie lost. She took off her watch.

“Come on,” Cole had exclaimed, and she laughed. He didn't argue, but when he lost the next game he ceremoniously removed his leather bracelet, humming the tune from the Olympics, and then tossed it onto his bed.

When Maggie lost the next game she was in a dilemma. She could remove her shirt and sit in only her bra and pants; she didn't like that one. So she removed her pants and sat bare-legged in her panties, her shirt tails covering herself up.

Cole lost the next one and he took off his belt. Another loophole in their game, she thought he'd be taking his T-shirt off.

So now they both sat, having some battle experience, both of them more familiar with their controls. Maggie was in her panties and bra and a button up white Oxford. Cole was in a T-shirt and his grey cotton pants.

She said, "You wearing underwear?"

He thought about it, eyes rolled up, thumbs hovering over the buttons of the controller. "No," he said.

"So I can win in two?"

Then he blurted, "Wait, no...I wore underwear today."

"Shoot," she said.

She won two in a row. The first victory she watched him stand, saw that he was mildly aroused, a curve of flesh pressing upwards eagerly against the crotch of his pants. He peeled his T-shirt off and sat back down, bare-chested. She tried not to look but did give a lingering glance to the round muscle of his shoulders, a fuzzy memory coming to her, a phantom feel on her palms knowing what his body felt like under her touch. Then, after the next loss, he rose and unbuttoned his pants and slipped out of them, let them fall to the floor and kicked them into the corner. Now he was only in a pair of white Y-front briefs.

"Too bad you're wearing underwear," she said coyly.

"You'd like that, huh?"

"I like to win," she said, her eyes staying on the shape of his manhood under the briefs. Her nipples had swollen and she hadn't realized it at first but now she was aware of their tightness as they dragged under the fabric. She could see the swell of his semi-arousal, could see the pouch created in the fabric from the large size of his testicles. She looked away.

"This is it, Margaret," he said.

They played and he won. "Shit," she said. Unbuttoned her shirt and let it fall off her shoulders, used her hands to cover herself even though she was wearing a bra. His eyes went over her as she sat back down. Her heart thumped in her chest.

"Stop looking at me," she said, and he laughed. Then he won the next goddamn game. He was getting a handle on Kitana's techniques.

"Let's see em, Maggie," he laughed.

"You're such a little kid," she said, mad. A real anger was coming up in her. An arousal too, but maybe the anger was arriving to do battle with the

feelings she shouldn't have. Maybe the anger was at herself for being aroused by this.

She folded her arms up behind her and it thrust her chest in his direction. She shook her head at the eager look on his face and chastised him with her eyes. He didn't look away.

"That's a beautiful bra, Margaret," he said.

"Thanks." She looked down, saw her small but perky breasts filling out the peach tulle of her bra. It had fancy scalloped trim, a bow in the center and a bow where each strap connected to the cup. She heard the snap give and let the straps slide down her shoulders. Cole's eyes remained focused on her breasts, wanting to see them revealed.

"You pervert," she said and covered herself up as the bra fell to the floor. She pressed a forearm across her chest and threw her bra near her shoes. Cole watched anyway, his smile arrogant, his eyes unwavering, watching for her arm to accidentally reveal her nipples. His cock was erect. She could see it, the fat swollen head of it pushing up a knot against the fabric of his briefs. It went on an angle towards his hip, the wide belly of it scored by the Y trim of the underwear's opening. It had pushed the shorts' fabric higher than the waistband, the stretched cotton ball of his glans touching his belly.

"Who's the pervert now, Margaret?"

"What?" she laughed. "I was just thinking how it's going to be hilarious to see you run up and down the halls with that giant boner."

"You wouldn't give me a minute to let it go down?"

"On its own?"

"Yeah," he said. She had visions of Jay convincing her the only way his erection would go down was if she jerked it off. She knew better, but it was fun to get caught up in his game.

"No. I'd make you run like that. Serves you right for making me play your dumb game."

"Maybe if you were a better player, Maggie, you wouldn't be naked and then I wouldn't be hard."

"Here," she said, a glum raising of her eyebrows as she took her hands away and revealed her erect nipples. She sat down and raised her arms with the controller to cover his view of them. "Let's just play, please."

"You worried?"

“You can't get in my head, Cole. We're both down to our undies, but I swear you'll be streaking.”

“Let's go,” he said, his voice full of bravado.

Their last fight was a long match. A lot of back and forth, a lot of flips to stay out of his range. She blocked like never before. She slipped and flipped. She worked up a real live sweat. She had Kitana backed up, her stupid Japanese forearms held up to protect herself, but she was relentless and Cole had no opportunity to launch a counter-attack without leaving Kitana open to a devastating split-punch to her little crotch.

Then, no idea how, she got rocked with somersault kicks and a bunch of lightning fast one-twos and Johnny Cage was fazed.

“Shit, no, oh no, no, no, no,” she yelled, almost at the top of her lungs. Then Cole's Kitana slid up to her dazed player and planted a gentle kiss on his lips. “Fuck, no,” she whispered. Johnny inflated like an inner tube, his eyes bulged, his mouth hosed blood, then she saw an animated x-ray of his skull expanding and then splitting from his flesh and exploding all over the screen.

“In your face, Margaret,” Cole said quietly while the music soared. “Flawless victory, my dear.”

“Fucking bullshit,” she whispered. She wanted to slam the controller down but thought of poor Satinder.

He turned to her, swinging his legs around so he fully faced her. “I'm going to need those panties, Margaret,” he said.

She looked at him past the corner of her eyes.

“I know,” she said. She stood, kept her side to him, hooked her thumbs into the waistband of her panties and she shimmied them down her thighs, and when they got to her knees she let them drop. She flicked them at him with her pointed toes.

They hit his chin and he caught them in his grip before they fell to his lap. He said, “You're not a sore loser, are you, Margaret?”

She looked purposefully at the the erection straining his underwear and she smiled and said, “No, but I think I'm going to be.”

MAGGIE KNEW she shouldn't be doing this. Knew she should never have agreed to play strip Mortal Kombat in the first place. She'd rationalized that it was fun and carefree and the truth was *it wasn't*. Now she was climbing onto Cole's bed and he was going to put his erection in her anus. And she could rationalize again, and say it was as Cole had said—for *the greater good*, and that it wasn't sex—but there was nothing about this that was right.

That was the excitement, though, wasn't it? That was why she was crawling over his duvet without a stitch of clothing. Just like she did with Jay, she was going to boil her frog one burner increment at a time, turning up the heat tick by tick until she'd boiled that sucker. Maybe it made her a bad person but she still wasn't going to get out of the bed and put her clothes on, head back to her dorm and do some studying. That *would* be the right thing. She was going to rationalize it all away.

"A bet's a bet, Maggie," Cole said behind her with good humor as she walked across his narrow bed on her hands and knees. She didn't look back, and didn't want to think of what he was seeing from his angle. Hoped she looked good like this.

She lay on her back with her knees drawn up and held together, feet flat on his bed. Bunched his duvet around her, but didn't cover herself. Cole came to bed, his briefs poked out by his hefty hardness. He was lit by the table lamp next to the bed, Satinder's lamp by his desk, and the TV behind him. He put a knee on the bed and her body jostled with his arrival. Then he

was slipping in next to her. It was friendly and it was sexual all at once. Her heart was drumming away double-time.

He lay on his side next to her, his head propped in his hand, elbow dug into the mattress. Laying like they were side by side on a beach somewhere, not alone in his dorm room about to do something dirty because she lost a bet.

“Hey,” he said, “I liked meeting your friends this weekend.” His hand pulled up the duvet a little higher then it was working underneath at pulling his briefs down.

“Did you?”

“Yeah. I didn’t know much about you...I mean, you know, your parents or where you came from.”

“I don’t talk about it much.”

His hand emerged from under the covers and he held his white briefs, spun it like he was learning to rope, then flung them over to the chair where his book bag sat. They slapped the wall then dropped silently to the floor.

“Well, it was interesting,” he said. “I’ve known you so long and I loved to see, you know, where young Maggie came from. ...Turn over.”

“How?” she asked him.

“On your side, face the wall,” he said.

There were only two pillows, so she took the one she was using and bunched it up into a tight ball, slipped it under her ear as she turned to her side, putting her back to Cole. She drew her knees up.

“That’s good,” he said. He was moving around behind her, shaking the bed. The drawer was drawn open, a squeaky scraping sound. Something was removed and she heard a hollow high note, like a metal tin being pulled, accompanied by the sound of suction.

“What are you doing?” she asked him.

“Vaseline,” he said.

“Oh.”

“Yeah, I mean, I just...I guess...realized that while I knew you so well, there was so much more...” His hand moved along her rump, the dry top surface of his knuckles searching her crack, finding it, then parting her. Then his finger stroked around her anus and she felt the warm thick paste being spread. “...So much more to know. How long have we been friends?”

His finger tickled and circled her little bud and she started to squirm. “Uhh...well, exactly as long as Max, I guess. I met you two the same night.

Four years?"

"Four school years," he said.

"Right."

"You haven't been with Max for four years. You've been a couple for two years."

"Almost three. Our third anniversary is December..."

"Easy," he said as warning, one hand on her waist now. His finger slid gently inside her. Her thigh muscles flexed and she scrunched her toes.

"Yeah, so, you and me? ...Three years?"

"Mm-hmm," she said, her scalp tingling as he carefully stroked his finger in and out of her.

"We've had such a good time here. You ever worry that it's almost over?"

"A-all the time..."

"That feel okay?"

"Yeah."

"I worry too." He rolled then and she could tell he was on his back. He thrust the covers down and she could hear sticky Vaseline crackling, knew he was stroking his cock. She listened but she didn't turn to look. He rolled away and she heard him bumping and rummaging through the drawer. He returned to her and she felt his warmth near her back, felt his hot sticky cock press along the soft curve of her rump. It slipped against her skin as he reached above her head.

He said, "Not so much worry, I guess...put your arms up, grab the headboard...more like I'm, you know, stabbed with a real...profound sadness."

"Uh-huh," she said and she lifted her hands up towards the headboard, nodded her head forward til her ears were past her arms. Felt the finials of the headboard and her fingers wrapped around one, gripped it. She looked down, saw her nipples condense and stretch.

"Yeah, I don't want it to be over."

"Me neither," she said. He was wrapping fabric around her wrists. It was comfortable, satiny, and he wove it between her wrists and around them, then around the finial. She didn't stop him. Her heart beat even faster.

"I'm off to Harvard after the summer. I'll be in Cambridge. You and Max...who knows? ...NYC?"

"Maybe."

“You guys will be married. You’ll have your new lives. Maybe I’ll visit, but it would be so easy for it to just...dissipate. You know?”

“I don’t think it will,” she said.

“That’s why I really enjoyed being at your home.” His lips pressed on her bare shoulder, sucked lightly but so briefly on her. Her eyes closed and her pulse increased. “It made me feel so close to you.”

Then the head of his cock pressed against her tight aperture. She could picture it behind her closed eyes. That large corpulent shape with its ridges and its foreskin, mashing into her, pushing until the weakness of her opening gave way to him and he was swallowed.

“Oh God,” she sighed.

He pressed harder and her anus stretched against his intrusion. He was thick and hard and she felt that size spread her tight hole wide. It sunk into her slowly, the Vaseline easing its passage. Once she’d accepted his glans the rest of him brought no more pain. Now it just felt like a swollen lump being passed into her guts.

Cole continued, “I worry that we’ll grow apart... How’s that?”

“I’m good,” she gasped, then grunted.

“You know... I worry that we’ll just move on and our time here will be a funny memory.”

“Ah...ah-huh...”

“You okay?”

She sucked her lips into her mouth and pressed them between her teeth, hummed, *Mmm-hmmm*, let them plop out, said, “Yeah, I’m okay. You’re big.”

“Shh-sh, it’s okay. This is what I mean. Just be casual. Don’t fight it, Maggie. Want me to stop here?”

“Yeah,” she said.

He let it sit inside her, didn’t go deeper. His hand rested on her naked hip. He said, “All this time I’ve known you I never considered you weren’t always this fun, happy carefree girl.”

“No...high school...was hard...” she said. Her tummy bunched and she pulled her elbows toward her hips but his binding tightened. She flexed her tummy harder, felt his hardness slipping against her insides, her flexing making her colon muscles clamp tighter on him.

“That feels good. You doing that on purpose?”

“Does it...feel good?” she said.

“Fuck yes. It feels really good. You still okay?”

“Yeah,” she whispered.

“Want me to go a little deeper?”

“Sure.”

Then he was sliding again and she felt her sphincter stretch wider, felt the knot of his head grinding through her membranes inside her. It was different now. The pain was gone, reduced to discomfort, and her heart raced at the thought of how awful it was what she was doing. Her eyes roamed his room, what she could see of it. The bare wall dead ahead, a poster down past her bare feet that read on the top “*God is Dead,*” - *Nietzsche, 1883* and below that, “*Nietzsche is dead,*” - *God, 1900*. She could see his books and bag and crumpled clothes on an upholstered chair with arms, sitting by the door like a guard. Her folded sweater rested on top.

This was so wrong, so bad, and that made it all the more exciting. This was her best friend. Four years—no, three—she’d known him. In all that time they had never been sexual. Not even remotely. His charm was apparent and undeniable. But here she was now and she was familiar with his cock. His most secret thing he had. She shared it with him. She’d sucked it, been fucked by it, now it was up her ass. But it wasn’t as dirty as it might seem. There was a sweetness to it. A friendliness, like he understood her desire for exploration and he was sharing his knowledge with her. As though she’d told him she wanted to go to Venice and he took her and kindly showed her all the sights because he’d been before. It felt kind of...nice.

And it was that paradox that made the dirtiness grander. Not in scale, but in a sense, scope. Looking back from afar and seeing what she was doing in the context of her friendship with Cole and Cole’s friendship with Max this was so lascivious. And so...sexy. Her thighs started to squirm. Now she was seeing what he meant about relaxing. She wasn’t fighting it now. Now she was digging it. She could feel a wetness rising in her. Feel her arousal begin to come to the surface of her skin inside and out.

“That’s what I mean about your friends,” he said as though he was unaware of the transformation happening to her. “Like, I know you weren’t close, but—”

She gasped, “They weren’t...my friends. They were just...kids I did my...homework with. My mom doesn’t...get that.”

He was quiet a moment and she felt his eyes on her. He said, "Am I your friend?"

"Yeah," she said, more wistfully than she intended. Her head twisted between her arms, pulled back, turned so she could see his face in her periphery. "A real friend."

HER EYES WERE on his lips as they settled against the curve of her shoulder and kissed her gently. "I'm glad," he said.

"You knew that."

"Yeah, doesn't mean I don't like to hear it."

Her eyes darted over his. He looked up to where her wrists were bound. His hand came to her neck and he rubbed her. "Too tight? You okay?"

"Yeah..."

"Your head is turned to me... Your neck sore?"

"No... I like to look at you."

"I can fuck your ass face to face."

"You can?"

"Sure. Between your legs, you put your knees up high, under my arms, I could fuck your ass and we could kiss too."

"Oh my God," she sighed breathily, her eyes closing and her pulse racing.

"You want me to do it from the front?"

In a struggling moment of clarity she managed to croak, "We better not. We...shouldn't do that..."

He watched her face a moment, said, "How does it feel now?"

"Good," she told him, her head still pointed over her shoulder at him. "It doesn't hurt. Max and I haven't had anal sex, really. We...started just last week. I like it, but..."

"I'm bigger than Max?"

"You are. You're really thick. You feel good, you know...in the front."

His features scrunched in stupefied humor. "The front? Your pussy?"

She laughed, turned and pushed her face through her arms again, hiding her face from him in the pillow. "That's what I meant," she laughed into the cotton.

“Shy Maggie. You’re so fucking cute,” he said and she felt his warm lips kissing her shoulder again, working a little higher up her collar and further tightening her nipples.

She peeked back and he kissed her lips. She let him, her lips parting for him, but they stayed unanimated. Then she kissed his cheek, down to the cleft in his chin, but she broke away, said, “I don’t think we should kiss when he’s not around.”

He smiled. “Just have anal, right?”

“No. Not that. I lost a bet. This isn’t sex.”

“One more,” he said and he kissed her again and she still couldn’t refuse. Thankfully he didn’t try again.

She whispered, “That’s it though, I mean it. Okay?”

“Okay. I want you to know you can take this, that’s all.”

“Okay.”

“You’re taking it.”

“I am,” she giggled. “It doesn’t hurt.”

“I told you.”

“Does Max have...does he have a small dick?”

“Maggie, don’t ask that.”

“Sorry.”

“Max is my buddy.”

“He’s my fiancé.”

“His cock is normal, I guess. What do I know? I have no experience with cocks. You’re supposed to know.”

“I don’t. Don’t you see them all the time...you know...in locker rooms?”

“Not hard, Maggie. And I don’t look. I don’t want to talk about Max’s dick.”

“Okay.”

“I’m going deeper. That okay?”

“Yeah, okay,” she gasped.

He slid himself more deeply inside her and there was little pain. Just a high stretching note that was also distinctly pleasurable. She didn’t know how much of his thing was inside her body but she knew she felt his pubic hair tickling at her sensitive butt cheeks.

“Are you all the way in?” she whispered, curious.

“No, but pretty close. I told you it was no big deal. I figured it was uncomfortable because Max was there. When you stiffened up, and like,

rejected it, Max supported that. Helped you away from something I knew you could do and would feel good. You think he'd ever let us be alone?"

"We are alone."

"I mean to have sex, Maggie. You know what I mean. Sometime I'd like to go real slow with you. Take my time. Do you think we could do that?"

"I don't know."

"Would Max be okay with that?"

"You could ask him."

He laughed, said, "You should ask him."

"I think he would want to be there."

"He's not here now."

She said, "We're not having sex, Cole. Not really."

"We're not. You're right. Just teaching each other."

"What am I teaching you?"

"I want to find out what you like. Move around on me. Show me. Show me what feels good..."

"I don't...think I should..."

"I think that's what you like about it. I think—"

She whispered, "Cole, don't..."

"You don't want this to feel good, Margaret?"

She gasped, her hands turned to fists and she strained at the cloth that bound her. A glowing bed of coals began in her belly. Desire. A furnace of badness. "Ah, don't...don't call me Margaret right now..."

"Don't you want it to feel good?"

"I do..."

"Show me. Show me what feels good..."

"I don't think we should have sex..."

"It's not sex. It's like homework. You're a good student. Show me, Margaret. Show me what you like..."

Her breaths came steadily, so as not to stoke her coals, her lips pulled in and she focused. Focused on his big hard column he'd put up inside her. Put it in a bad place, not her sex place. Focused on the pleasure that brought to her anyway. Her hips swiveled minutely, the muscles of her ass flexing in undulating waves. She found what felt good. She sculpted the shape of his glorious cock with her insides, gripped it with her rectum, pinched it with her sphincter, found how his swollen glans brought her deep pleasure. She worked a pattern, worked a groove, right cheek flex, hip dip, swoop up and

to the left, repeat. She did that and the pleasure came. Her heart was slamming around crazily in her chest like an off-kilter washing machine.

Cole groaned, squeezed her shoulder, said, "Are you drawing a J?"

She pictured it, the way her hips swayed. "Yeah," she gasped. "Does it feel good for you?"

"You feel amazing," he said. "You see how you're relaxing?"

"Yeah," she agreed.

"Yeah, it's no big deal, Maggie. Nice and easy." His hand came around and lightly stroked her belly and he got it fluttering. It made her tighten up on his cock.

"Ah," he sighed, "mm, that feels good on me." His touch was so light and delicate, thrumming her from below her belly button to her ribs. "Nice and easy now, feel it slide in you. That's you, not me. I'm not doing that. I want to know what you like..."

"It feels good," she sighed. Her eyes had closed again and she bit her lip. Her mind's eye was focused on the tight wet ring of her sphincter and the tickle as it slipped along her friend's thick cock, could feel the squiggle of his veins as they were pressed by her tightness.

His hand was gone from her tummy and she hadn't noticed until she became aware that it was working at something else. He was moving around, digging under the pillow. When it came back she saw he was holding something.

"What is it?" she asked.

"Shh-sh," he shushed her. Now she could see it was a long bullet-nose plastic column in bright sky-blue. He gripped it and his fingers worked a button near the base. A vibrator.

"Oh Cole..." she said, a worried feeling crossing her, like this was going to be going a little too far.

He got it humming, a very quiet model, barely audible, a tiny high-powered and well-greased little battery operated motor in it. His hand grasped her thigh, up high where it met her hip. Her head nodded down and watched the hand as it slid low and lower until he gripped her knee. The vibrator hummed. Her knee was lifted, an easy motion, and while she resisted it was marginal and her legs were eased open, her pussy bared. His hand went up and down her inner thigh and he got her moaning. "Cole, I don't think...we can't..."

“I want you to know what it can be like, Maggie, I want you to relax. Promise me you’ll relax,” he whispered. The vibrator touched her and she jumped, her ass gripped his cock tightly.

“No, Cole, that’s dirty. You’ve touched other girls with it...”

“No, I haven’t. I bought this one for you, Maggie. I swear. Check my garbage you’ll find the box.”

Her face contorted by the trouble that was brewing here. This was definitely forbidden. But the vibrator persisted and she let him explore her. Cole moved the buzzing tip of the vibrator along her swollen labia, felt that it slipped right along her. Maybe her own wetness, she was definitely aroused, but also maybe some of the Vaseline spreading between her legs. Whatever the method of the lubrication, the touch of that humming dildo was peeling her scalp back. Her mouth had fallen open and she ached to hold his wrist and guide his hand to where she wanted it. Her hands tugged at their binding and her back arched. That squeezed his cock, and it slipped inside her deeply.

“Oh fuck,” she laughed.

“Maggie likes it?”

“Mm-hmm,” she hummed while she sucked her own lips. Her hips resumed their J pattern, her haunches flexed and her ass gulped up and down at Cole’s magnificent size. He didn’t hurt anymore. He didn’t even feel uncomfortable. Now all she could think about was the pleasure from the dildo, the buzzing, the tingle, the vibrations that sent unbelievable bolts of pleasure through her. She began to bounce and buck, her tummy chugging. She laughed again. Closed her eyes more tightly and ignored the brightness of the room, ignored that she was doing this with her best friend and ignored that her Max would be upset by this. Her toes scrunched so tightly they pinched her calf where they were folded over.

Her lips pouted and she began to groan on her exhale, felt her lips wobbling with the briskness of her exhalation. *Oh*, she began to softly sigh each time she breathed out. Cole stayed quiet and she was thankful. She could believe this wasn’t sexual if he stayed quiet. This was homework. This was two friends learning about their new lifestyle and just like Max and Cole went to the gym this was her and Cole bettering themselves. Building themselves up so when they next performed they would be *better*. It wasn’t sex. It was just exploring.

So she worked on the dildo. Clenched her eyes so tightly shut her brow must have been furrowed with lines. But she could feel her orgasm and she just had to find it now, her arms going out in the dark, blindly hoping to bump into it. But the more her hips worked and the more Cole stroked her with the bright blue vibrator, the more that orgasm glowed. She could sense it now, moved herself nearer to it. Her breaths came quicker and quicker, her hips moved with rising intensity. She began to moan and form words of encouragement. She could see it now, her orgasm, its glow rising to a spark and she ran to it, didn't want to lose it again.

"Ah shit, ah shit," she cried out, her back humping out and thumping Cole's chest. Her legs slapped together, collapsing and squeezing, knocking the dildo into the sheets somewhere where it continued its mechanical hum. She tightened right up, her knees pressing tight, her mouth open in a silent blind scream, and as she came long and hard her ass slowly lifted along Cole's shaft and she felt the swollen knot of his cock head dragging out to her sphincter and now she cried out again as another orgasm tore at her while the first one had mildly subsided.

"Oh," she cried, then thrashed and Cole's arm went around her chest and he hugged her, tried to keep her still. Her elbows thrust toward her tummy, her wrists catching on her binding and pinching her. She tightened every muscle in her body and she writhed against Cole, felt his cock sliding in her and right now she swore it felt like twice the size when he put it in her. She coughed. She coughed and it turned to a laugh as she came out of it. Cole still held her and they began to fade, began to settle into the mattress again. She slumped, breathing heavy and hoarse, a giggle emerging from her and Cole kissed her shoulder.

"There," he said. "You got the hang of it."

The vibrator hummed in the sheets and she looked down her body. Saw her nipples in stretched pink buds, her belly heaving in and out, a sweaty sheen on her. Her sex was wet and shining as well, her thighs pressed together in a damp seam. Cole's hand was on her waist, she felt his cock in her ass and her pleasure was ruined by a sudden rising remorse. She knew better. What the fuck was that? *That was sex.*

"Can you untie me," she whispered. Her head slumped on her arm and her eyes flicked left and right, she chewed the corner of her mouth.

Cole's hand gripped her at the bend of her hip and thigh, and he drew his cock out of her. A cold blast entered her. A stinging cold, and she tried to

squeeze her buttohole but it didn't respond. She hissed mildly and he kissed her shoulder again. Then his hands were moving above them, she felt her wrists being tugged as he unwound the satiny cloth that he'd tied her with. She felt shame over that as well. Letting herself be tied. Max would be devastated. She squeezed wet from her eye and blinked it away.

Imitation

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 4TH

COLE GOT off the bed and he was moving around his room but she still stared at the wall. He bounced back next to her in a moment and she felt a dry and scratchy towel wiping at her back. He went up and down her waist, where he'd touched her with his Vaseline-coated cock. Then he wiped her crack and she opened her legs with the help of his guiding hand and he rubbed the towel over her sex.

She soothed her wrists now, shaking her head and coming out of her sadness. She wouldn't burden Cole with regret and woe, he didn't need that. No guy likes drama.

Her hands went between her legs and she took over for him, taking a corner of the towel and wiping her sex and the inside of her thighs until they were relatively clean. He did his own cleanup as well, she was aware of him bundling the towel around his erection and rubbing it. When she rolled to face him, he sat up higher on his pillow, put one knee up, the towel covering his hardness.

"There, see," he said. "I don't know...if you resist it, it makes a barrier..." he was attempting charm but there was an uncomfortable manner to his speech.

"Yeah, I know," she said.

"So, now, next time..."

"Yeah, I'll be more open."

Their conversation was stunted and awkward, vaguely administrative somehow. The two of them loved to laugh but treating their ridiculous act

they'd just performed like it had educational merit. Afraid that laughing now, in post-coital regret, they would together discern the badness in what they had done. Maybe just like her, Cole felt guilty about coercing his best friend's girlfriend into a sexual act.

They made lingering eye contact and it was like each of them wanted to say something first. She was even with his chest, his head was cocked forward, leaning his shoulders back against the pillow pressed to the headboard. She was naked, on her side and she gathered up a sheet from under his duvet and tucked it around her chest, the whole while still blankly darting her eyes over his. She broke away first and she bowed her head until her clammy forehead came to rest on the warm skin of his chest.

Without looking at him her spirits were raised. She said, almost to herself but wanted him to hear, "Why did I let you do that? That was so stupid."

He said nothing but he held his breath. She shook her head back and forth, the pivot point where she rested her brow on him. He began to laugh. He tried to stop himself but it made him twitch and it bounced her head.

She laughed too, light exhalatory bursts from her nose. With that, he laughed freely, not guffaws, just a joyful chuckle. She raised her face to him again, saw his handsome gaze lowered to her, a lopsided smile narrowing his eyes.

She made a dumb face, her eyebrows tenting glumly. "A bet's a bet, Maggie," she repeated, imitating his words to her but lowering it to an oafish mumble.

Now he laughed out loudly and covered his face with both his hands, continuing the laugh into them. She thumped her forehead against him. When he regained his composure he returned her gaze, looked in her eyes, said, "It wasn't that hard to convince you. Strip Mortal Kombat? ..."

She shied away, but let him see her smiling.

"Are we going to tell Max?" he asked her.

"I don't know now. I don't know how I'd explain it. It's so stupid. We played a strip game and I lost a bet. It's ludicrous. He'd like it better if I told him I just asked you to do it."

"Tell him that."

"I don't want to lie."

"We don't *need* to tell him at all."

"You wouldn't feel bad about that?"

He inhaled deeply and looked across the room, down to the foot of the bed. "I would, I guess. But...what's the point?"

"In telling him? He doesn't want to be excluded. It would hurt him."

He didn't answer her, eyes cast again now in deep thought toward the door to the hall. After a while he said, "You and Max...you're doing this for you?"

Her chin planted in his muscle and she looked in his eyes, then lightly nodded.

"What does Max want?"

She shrugged now. "I don't know. He wants me to not be curious."

"He wants you to have experience?"

"Yeah."

"He gets off on this?"

That was true. She knew that was true but she didn't feel right admitting that. That was personal and it belonged to her and Max. Her mouth worked around while Cole's eyes stayed on hers and she admitted, "He doesn't hate it."

He thought a while again, she watched his eyes dart around while his mind worked away. "You've got ten months until your wedding. You want to have experiences in that time... You'll never cheat on Max?"

"When we're married? Never."

"You've never cheated?"

"With who?" she laughed.

"Honestly?" he said, fixing her with a serious gaze.

She thought of her afternoons with Jay. Of having a handsome young dude in her room, having him strip naked in the daylight so she could draw him. Fooling herself as much as Cole might be fooling himself tonight. Rationalizing away sexual desire for the greater good, whether it was the Arts or easing a naïve young woman into accommodating anal sex.

"No," she said, firmly, "I've never cheated."

"So you'll never have a fling? Never have a wild affair?"

She smirked, cocked an eyebrow at him, "No. Why? What are you getting at?"

"Sneaking around and having wild sex when you shouldn't might be one of the hottest things you'll ever experience."

"Oh brother," she laughed.

“It’s true. Driven by passion and lust, wild forbidden sex. The fear of being discovered but just having to do it anyway...”

“You want me to cheat on Max?”

“It wouldn’t be cheating.”

“It would hurt him.”

“If he wants you to do the things you won’t do when you’re married...” he let the rest hang in the air.

“But it *would* be cheating, and if Max...”

“Hold on,” he said with a smile. He eased her chin off him, and slipped out of the bed. She watched as he went across the room, completely naked. His ass was round and firm, perfect. His body wasn’t as muscular as Jay but somehow that was more endearing, less intimidating. He still had a beautiful body. Thin and lean, narrow hipped but with wide and round shoulders and big muscular arms. As he made his way to his pants she could see the end of his cock stiffly bobbing, still upright and still eager. He went through the pocket of his pants and he returned with his iPhone, slipped back into bed with her and she rested her chin on him again.

“Now... Sit up,” he said. “Cover yourself.” He motioned like he was pulling a jacket on. She rose to sit cross-legged next to him, shrouded herself in their shared bed sheet.

“Don’t look so sour,” he laughed, holding his phone up and filming her, watching her in the view screen.

“What are you doing?” she asked and she put her hand out to cover the phone.

“Seriously. Legal inculpability. Now, sit up straight.”

She sat up straight, tucked both arms back under her sheet, sitting and eyeing him like a dubious monk.

“Repeat after me.”

“Go ahead,” she said, rolled her eyes.

“I, Maggie Becker...”

“I, Maggie Becker,” she mimicked.

“On this day, Wednesday, October fourth...”

“On this day, Wednesday, October the fourth...”

“Am stating that I will engage in surreptitious, covert, and very dirty behavior...”

She repeated, “Am stating that I will engage in...what?”

“Surreptitious, covert, and very dirty behavior...”

“I will engage in surreptitious, covert, and very dirty behavior.”

“...But I am doing so because it is part of the experience. This is fake cheating.”

“I am doing so because it is part of the experience. It is fake cheating,” she said, smiling and cocking her head for the camera. Doing it for Cole, then wincing thinking of Max watching the video. But she wasn’t going to cheat and he wasn’t going to see the video.

Cole put his hand on his chest, over his heart, said, “I want to experience the excitement of cheating but I swear to all that is holy, that I am not really cheating. Now put your hand on your heart...”

She put her hand over her heart under the sheet. “I want to—”

“Let me see your hand,” he said.

“No,” she laughed, “I’m not opening the sheet. I want to experience...what?”

“The excitement of cheating...”

“The excitement of cheating but I am not really cheating.”

Cole added, “I love you, Max.”

She felt her features fall and her head tilted further. “I love you, Max. I do. I really do. Very much.”

The phone dinged as he stopped recording and he tossed it onto the bed at his side. “What do you think?” he said, his face serious again.

“I think this is that erection talking,” she said without a smile, nodding her chin towards the bulge under his side of the bed sheet he’d gathered over his prominent arousal.

He looked between his legs, gripped his shaft over the cotton and held it. “Maybe,” he said. “Think about it, would you? It could be fucking wild.”

“Maybe,” she said. “That video wouldn’t save me. And I don’t want to hurt Max. Not for real. This isn’t a court of law, and that declaration wouldn’t spare his feelings.”

His grip went mildly up and down his cock, he said, “I don’t want to hurt Max. You could have the thrill of your life, though. I mean it.”

She ruffled the sheet, flapped it like a cape and her arm slipped closer to him, her hand resting on the middle of his bare thigh. She moved it higher, sliding under the sheet that covered him as well. His hand left his cock and his eyes leveled at hers.

“Just think about it,” he said.

Her hand wanted to slip up his leg higher but she resisted it. Cole's eyes were fixed on his bulge and her hand and the maddening distance between the two. His breaths came heavy. Finally, when she remained still, he said, "You want to watch me jerk off?"

She laughed so abruptly her other hand shot up to cover her unladylike exhortation.

"What?" he laughed, his trim stomach bouncing, his eyes twinkling light back at her.

"Oh, nothing," she said, remembering Jay and his ploy to get her to jerk his cock. "Just you boys and your cocks."

Now her hand slipped up higher and she felt the heat from his manhood. She eased closer, bumped his scrotum with her nails and felt his balls climb high. She walked her fingers across his sticky sagging skin and she cradled them.

Cole peeled the sheet back and they both looked at her pale small hand holding his huge testicles. His cock was iron hard, looked like it wanted to split, the skin was stretched so tight on it. It shot straight up to his belly button, thick and writhed with veins. His foreskin had bunched around the collar and his swollen glans, large and plump, flared from it. Her hand went around the base, gripped it lightly, her hand forming a wide C around his tremendous girth. She moved her hand up and down and watched his foreskin gulp then peel from the corpulent glans. His hips began to grind gently, moving his shaft through her grip.

"I'm not going to cheat on him," she said, though she wasn't sure she was talking to Cole. More talking to herself, her eyes on the thing she had in her hand.

"We could have so much fun and it would be just pretend."

She didn't answer him, kept stroking. Heard his words and was contemplating. The desire was there, the urge to have sex was strong, to do it in secret even stronger but she wasn't into hurting Max for real. But she was stroking another guy's cock now. No lube, just using his foreskin and the sparse greasy remnant of wiped Vaseline.

She brought her hand away from him, his cock so hard it barely wagged when she let it go. She daintily smelled her palm.

Cole laughed, said, "What is that?"

"It was...you know...in my butt."

“You prude,” he said, then he sat up and kissed her forehead. He held her chin and looked in her eyes. “God, you’re so beautiful.”

“Don’t,” she whispered. “I like when you say it, but I don’t want you to. Not now.”

He grinned warmly, ran her hair behind an ear and said, “Okay.”

She leaned her head on him, rested it on his chin, her hand returning to his aching erection, poking up straight between his legs. She resumed her stroking, her eyes lowered to her grip on him. She didn’t want to hurt Max, but this was cheating—and then again maybe it wasn’t. Who knew anymore? Just two good friends getting each other off. They had a threesome and they would again and this was about exploration... This wasn’t passion, wasn’t ecstasy...she was clear-headed. Her hand was just going to hold this part of his body she’d held before, and it was going to go up and down, then shortly, fluid was going to siphon through tubes and vessels and emit from the hole in the end of it. That was all. Just biology. Not romance, nothing of the heart. Just bodily function.

“Like that?” she whispered.

He groaned and eased his cock through her stroking hand.

“Like my hand on you?” she said softly, her eyes going up to look at his face.

“Like it in your hand?” he said.

“I do,” she said.

“It looks so good in your hand.”

“You’ve got a nice cock,” she said, watching how it looked in her grip. She had small pale hands, but long-fingered. They wrapped around his shaft, just enough to touch middle finger to thumb tip. His skin was dark and wrinkled and it looked so unlike the rest of him. Penises were ugly sort of things. Awesome in their own way and definitely exciting. But Cole was beautiful. He had tight tan skin, lustrous and thick blonde hair, and bright blue eyes. Then between his legs he had this odd wrinkled tool. And hanging below it, two grotesque balls inside a hairy sack. So strange when considered in the entirety, but still...she desired it. Loved the feel of it in her hand, loved to feel it hard, loved to feel it transform from soft to hard, to know that she had the power.

“I’m going to come...is that okay?”

“I want you to,” she said, looking up at his questioning face, seeing the light reflect in his narrowed diffident eyes.

SHE STROKED HIM SENSUALLY. Too sensually to be considered friendly. Altering her touch on him, varying her speed, she spent a good long while keeping the orgasm from him, stopping him from coming. She admired the shape of his cock in her hand. The two of them sitting upright on his bed, naked, folded against one another, her hand between his legs, the only sound the quiet paused interlude from Mortal Kombat and the smacking of his foreskin.

She secretly watched his face now as she stroked him. Saw his handsome stubbled jawline, his plump perfectly shaped lips. His eyes were closed as she delivered him pleasure. This was her good friend. Not the one from her bridal day, not the man with the tie who backed her against a wall and had her breath trapped in her throat. Not the one who said the dirtiest things to her, put his hand in her panties and whose touch almost made her come. This was the Cole she knew and loved. As a friend.

She liked the other Cole better. He did strange things to her heart. This one was fun but it was tentative, operating with trepidation. When he knew he could fuck her he became a force. Frightening in his dominant sexuality, but now, while he was still trying, there was restraint. He was worried about Max. He was worried about doing something that might hurt him. But not worried enough to stop. Instead, manufacturing convoluted games to get in her pants. She provoked something in him. She had to. He’d endeavored to engage her in passion, to make it seem friendly and natural...but he’d been prepared. Vaseline at the ready, going to the store and buying her a bright blue dildo. His own desire for her was apparent in those actions. And, with his cock in her hand, she had very bad feelings—wondering what it would be like to cheat. Wondering what it would be like to be consumed by a man like Cole when he wore his tie and knew what he was doing.

Maybe he was right about cheating.

She whispered in his ear, “What happened to the man who made me soak my panties?”

“What do you mean?”

“The Cole with the tie who met me in the hall at The Poirot was so dirty, so sexy, he made my knees shake. Literally shake.” She kept her stroke and said, “I miss that confident man who knew exactly what turned me on...put his hand up my skirt when my mother could walk through the door at any minute...”

He frowned, moved his hand down his belly.

“What? ...” she said, slowing, their eyes coming together.

He didn’t answer but he held her wrist and stopped her stroke.

Finally he smiled, said, “He put his cock up your ass when you didn’t really want to...”

“I kind of wanted to...”

“No, you didn’t”

“I knew I shouldn’t...”

Their eyes met again and his face wasn’t quite so happy now. He was trying to comprehend her. Then he bounced himself on top of her. He did it so fast she threw her hands up to defend herself like he would strike her. But no blows came. Only kisses. Passionate and overwhelming and she wanted to succumb but she knew she couldn’t.

“No,” she gasped, “...I don’t mean...”

His knees spread her legs and she resisted but not hard enough. He got her open and his cock poked around her sex, the fat glans stroking the seam of her thigh trying to find her wet heat.

“Oh Cole, no, seriously...”

He persisted and she kissed him but she flexed her thighs and closed her legs against his hips, made it hard for him to get his cock inside her. He found her wet stripe anyway and she felt the head of his cock spread her labia, heard the mucous sound of her sex being parted.

“Cole, don’t,” she hissed and she squirmed in his grip. He persisted but slowly he faltered.

“Maggie,” he said, and his kisses came away.

“I mean it,” she said. His eyes darted over hers. Lost. Mad. Mad at her. His heart was racing. He held his cock in his hand.

He said, “I don’t know what you want. I know what I want...I don’t know—”

“I want you. I do, but you know we can’t...”

“I...”

She shimmied herself higher up the bed and twisted to the night table. He'd left the jar of Vaseline with the lid off and she dipped her fingers and took a generous scoop. Worked her body back underneath him, getting her thighs on the outside of his. He planted his hands on the mattress on either side of her.

"Kiss me," she said.

He looked at her dubiously, his handsome blues darting over her whole face, his brow furrowed. His hair hung down over her and in this dim light she thought he couldn't be more handsome. "Kiss me," she said again. She worked her hands together, got them coated in grease. He kissed her. She kissed him back with intent. Taking his tongue and moaning and writhing under him. She broke the kiss, said, "That's it, now fuck my tight little pussy," and she gripped his aching hardness with both her fists and pushed it downward so it lay in her hands against her belly.

He inhaled with lascivious intent and then resumed his kiss. His cock began to thrust through her hands and she gripped him tightly. He was hard as steel right now and feeling her hand being spread surprised her that her sex could accommodate his girth. But it did. It did and he felt good too. "Fuck that pussy," she whispered and it spurred him. It worked well, the positioning was almost perfect, her tight grip held his size effectively and she could take his rising desire. He fucked her hands faster and faster, kissed her neck and began to breathe lustily against her collar. "That's it, Cole, fuck that little pussy so hard...fuck it good..."

"Fuck, Maggie," he grunted.

His heavy swinging balls tapped her labia wetly and she gasped, "Come inside it, Cole, fill it up with your hot come..."

"Oh shit," he seized, then roared, and she felt her hands become instantly slippery. Then he was ejaculating all over her chest and over her belly and she gripped him as tight as she could. It kept spewing from him and sending hot dots and splashes over her breasts and even her arms. He thrust and grunted, bellowed and dug his cock deep through her grip like he was burying it to the hilt in her body. His cock flexed and bulged, throbbed in her hand as his muscles worked to propel every drop out of his hanging balls.

"Fuck, Cole," she whispered. "That is a lot of come."

He groaned a wheezy constricted laugh into her hair. She lowered a hand to hold his testicles and she caressed them, said, "These aren't for

show, huh?”

“You’re so dirty, Maggie,” he laughed into the pillow.

“Mm,” she moaned, squeezed his cock and his balls. He might be satisfied but now she wasn’t. Sure he’d made her come already but that hot little escapade had her wishing his cock was inside her. “Get off me, Cole...I...with my legs open like this...I want to...that video wouldn’t save me...”

He eased away from her and she was reluctant to let his manhood go. He flopped next to her, glistening chest heaving to catch his breath.

“We’re so...we’re so good together...” he sighed heavily.

“Yeah,” she said, hands feeling around her, looking for that towel while his semen dribbled off her, tickling her, running along her collar and onto her neck. Found it, then cleaned herself and watched his ceiling.

“Shit, I mean it, Maggie. You are incredible.”

She turned nervously, regarded him as he lay as she had been, flat on his back, looking up above, eyes wide but vacant. He was recovering from the dirty thing they’d just done.

“Yeah, we are,” she said as she watched him. She admired his muscle, his hair, that gleam in his upturned eyes. He was her friend, her beautiful friend. She would love to have a secret affair with him, but it would kill her sweet boy.

IT WAS after ten o'clock and Maggie wasn't in her room. Max stood outside her door, 211, having knocked now a dozen times. She wasn't home. Unless she was passed out. But not on a Wednesday, not Maggie.

Unless she was cuddled up in her bed right now with Cole. The two of them accidentally falling asleep after a vicious, passionate fucking and now they were laying under her sheets wide-eyed and snickering, putting a finger over each other's mouths, trying not to laugh, waiting for Max to go away. She wasn't responding to texts either. Her phone was going to message. He chewed the inside of his lip. The hall bustled behind him. Students going left and right, laughing, shouting out to one another, careless and problem free.

He strode down the hall, wondering what to do next. He texted Cole this time and watched his screen while he walked down the stairs to the main floor trying not to bump into anyone. Still no response.

Once out in the fresh air he took a few deep breaths and looked out over the quad from where he stood. Cold and crisp, dark, paths lit by the halide lights on posts. The paths were populated by sauntering students laughing and talking, people by themselves with headphones. A bike rode past. He squinted in the dark, scoping all the faces, looking to see if she was coming, see if she was out here.

He headed to the northeast, going along the path and thinking to curl around behind Keegan and cut across the athletic field, intending to dip into Farmingham village, head to Altieri's and see if they might still be there. He

paused at the edge of the grass where it met the concrete path, looking out across the dark plain ahead and the lit street ahead a few hundred yards off. He tapped his foot on the stone edge of the path. Changed his mind and walked back the way he'd come and headed towards Samuelson.

He walked briskly, putting some speed to his shoes. Somehow something bad was building inside him. He wouldn't ascribe the word premonition but it was something very akin. An intuition. Could he trust it? Sometimes the notion of intuition could be driven by hormonal desires and impulses. He headed to Samuelson blindly, his mind a blank wordless slate, but something deep down in his brain, something small and primitive was sure he would find them together. And the speed to his step? ...It felt a bit like desire. Like he wanted to catch them together.

He didn't slow. He pictured what he might find. His worst image. The one he'd had knocking at her door. Being left out. Her and Cole together and laughing at him, hiding under their sheets, sharing humor at dumb Max's misfortune. Knowing he'd be so mad they were fucking, but doing it anyway. He *was* mad. Mad, but he *wanted* to see it. Wanted the confirmation. Why would he want to see that? Why would...

At the same moment that his phone binged to life in his hand he saw a familiar shape, black against the lobby lights of Samuelson. It looked like his Maggie, moved like her. It emerged from the doors, held a phone in its grasp, hustled quickly down the steps, close enough to him that he could hear the heels of penny loafers on stone. He stopped in his tracks and looked at the screen.

*Maggie: Sorry sorry sorry. We were at Rockets and it was loud
neither of us heard our phones*

He stepped into the grass and stood himself behind a tall boxwood shrub and paused to think. That was Maggie coming out of Samuelson. He was sure of it. She wasn't coming out of Kirby Hall, the building that hosted Rockets café. If she had been at Rockets she would have texted him when she left there, not after she and Cole walked all the way back to Samuelson. It was a ten minute walk from Kirby to Samuelson.

His phone buzzed.

Maggie: where are u now? Meet me in my room...

He watched the shape approach. More sure now that it was her. He texted.

*Max: I'm on the athletic field, went to Altieri's...almost at Keegan.
Where are u?*

Maggie: I'm on North quad, almost home...see you there

The figure passed on the path, two arms length away. It was Maggie, head down, reading her screen, a hurried step carrying her quickly to meet him at her room. But she wasn't at North quad. That was where she would be if she was coming back from Kirby. She was at Samuelson quad. She was coming out of Cole's dorm. She was lying. His goddamn intuition was right. He stepped out onto the path in disbelief. He stood where she had just walked and he watched her back as she moved from him and made her way home. He *watched* her. *She lied to him.* And maybe just intuition again, maybe right, maybe wrong...there was a hitch to her gait. The kind of hitch that seeped into his mind as the belief that she was sore from having just fucked his best friend.

MAX FOUND her in her hall, on her toes, scanning over the passing heads looking for him. Her face showed relief when their eyes met. He forced a smile and it pained him. She waved, then leaned herself on the wall next to her door and waited for him to get to her. She smiled the whole time it took him to cross from the stairs. It was breaking his heart.

"Maxy," she said, her voice a breathy sigh, one of honest endearment, and she closed her eyes and put her arms around him. Despite the twisted pain he felt, her touch, her reaction, her feel against him made his heart soar. He held her tight.

She whispered at his shoulder, "How was your class?"

He pulled back to answer, but before he spoke her hand cupped his cheek and she kissed him, deeply and lovingly.

He gave it back to her, feeling his stiffness and discomfort being eased away. The honesty and passion he felt here now making him doubt what he saw with his own eyes. She had lied to him but her emotions were true. Her love for him was real. And somehow that heightened her deceit to stellar levels of arousal. His sweet Maggie so in love with him but just needing the action, just needing those things that other men could do to her. He grew hard in his pants and their loving kisses became more enlivened as he began to breathe deeply against her, press his chest to her and grind his hips against her, let her know his arousal.

She became aware, knew that was his hardness against her tummy right now.

“Come with me,” she said, eyes narrow and lusty, her smile still there but weakened by a libidinous rising.

Holding his hand, she used the free one to get her dorm room door open and she led him into the dark. The handkerchief was looped around the handle and the door closed. She left him, he heard her stumble in the dim and then the flea market lamp on her night table was turned on and he saw her looking at him.

“Maggie...” he started.

She came to him quickly, put her arms around his waist and looked in his eyes, said, “I need you...”

It felt vaguely like a dismissal as exciting as it was. He’d been about to announce that they should talk. They hadn’t been alone together since Sunday and they hadn’t had an in-depth discussion about what had transpired. Not that they didn’t have the time. They were busy but they could have made a meeting. Neither of them wanted to. That was the truth. Neither of them wanted to address the strangeness that was now consuming their love lives. But given tonight’s events; her and Cole witnessed through Altieri’s window, her being alone with Cole without him, her lying to him... He wanted to talk. However he was hard and she was eager and he could put off talking even more. He might just lose his nerve altogether.

He kissed her. Thought she would want that. Thought like Cole would think. Give her what Cole would give her. Max was handsome and sweet, and most of all, he was smart. He might not be as muscular, *as* handsome, or have a big dick, but he was smart enough to learn from his Maggie what turned her on. Maybe it was other men, and maybe he wasn’t against that,

but he knew in his heart that when he was with her he would not disappoint her. He would not wilt before her. He loved her too much.

He shoved her briskly to sit on the bed.

“Ow,” she laughed as she thumped down on her rump and bounced on her bed. Her jaw clacked audibly, her teeth gnashing together. “Max!” she laughed and her hand came up to soothe her mouth.

He pushed her back with a kiss, straddled her, and she lay back, her hands on his chest as he gave her his tongue. His hands roamed her body, handling her breasts over her sweater. He pulled back and whispered to her, “Did Cole make you horny?”

“What? ...” she whispered, a tentative hush restraining her voice.

Maybe they could do both. Maybe they could discuss their sex lives and maybe he could give her what she wanted all at once. He repeated, “You were with Cole all night, now you’re so fucking horny...”

She squeaked, struggled for an answer.

He whispered, “I bet when I put my hand in your panties I’m going to find a slippery mess.”

“Oh,” she sighed and he felt her tension wash away. A strength rose in him. He knew her. He knew her dirty little mind. His hand traveled from the cashmere of her chest, slowly down her belly and she arched her hips, rose them, eager for him to touch her. “Oh Max,” she sighed, and a wide smile broke his face but he pinched it off. He went lower, his clenched thumb and forefinger twisting her button open and then drawing down her zip. Her hips began to churn against him. With her pants undone his hand slipped easily under her panties.

“Oh, you little slut,” he hissed in mock surprise and disgust. “What a mess, you bad girl. All you ever think about is boys...”

She sighed a laugh and writhed under him, but he didn’t let up. His fingers slipped through her sex. Her labia were engorged and excited, slippery with her dirty arousal. He hooked a finger inside her and she spread her legs. He kissed her neck and up under her hair behind her ear. She gripped his arms with her hands and squeezed him fiercely.

“You suck his cock tonight? Tell me... You suck his cock?”

“No,” she gasped.

“You wanted to...”

“Ah,” she gasped, her fingers digging into him.

He pulled away and rose over her, his hands tugging under the waistband of her pants and pulling them down her thighs. Her flesh shook as she helped him, kicking her legs out of the pants and he threw them aside. He dove between her legs, kissing inside her knees and working his lips up the inside of her thighs.

“Oh, no,” she gasped out, with abrupt surprise and sitting up, closing her legs on his ears and stopping him. She looked troubled and their eyes met and held for a quiet moment.

“I want you up here,” she said softly, and her hands caressed his face.

He rose to stand over her, her sitting, him standing on the floor leaning over her.

He stared at her seriously. “You fuck him?”

She looked in his eyes and she bit her lip. His heart stopped. She shook her head no.

“You swear?”

She nodded. “I swear,” she whispered.

He resumed, his heart pounding relief in thundering pulses through his veins. The roar in his eardrums was deafening. She was a liar, lied about being at Rockets, but he could see in her eyes she meant that she hadn’t fucked Cole. Like she was proud to tell him she hadn’t. His hands went under her sweater, his mouth on hers. When he tried to raise it she stopped him.

“Just fuck me, Max.”

“You can’t wait?”

She shook her head, said, “No.”

“You wanted to fuck him, didn’t you?”

She kissed him instead of answering.

He pulled back, said, “Talk to me, Maggie. Tell me the truth. The truth is exciting, isn’t it?”

“Yeah,” she whispered.

His hands undid his own pants now, his lips back on hers while he worked. Her fingers touched at his hands in excitement, wanting his cock to be out. Brushing her hands away with his own, he whispered, “Get on your hand and knees, Maggie.”

Her eyes glistened, darting back and forth over his, wide and staring, and he felt so powerful. Twenty minutes ago she’d stabbed him in the heart but he was taking it back. “Get on all fours and show me your pussy,” he

said, his voice breaking and trembling, his confidence just a thin veil. She complied. Crawled herself up on to her bed and rolled over got on all fours and looked over her shoulder at him. Moving to her side he got close to her ear while his hand explored her hungrily. Not carefully, his whole had moving up her crack and over her anus, fingers stroking through her wet sex and rubbing her clit aggressively. Her thighs began to quiver. "Did you like fucking him, Maggie? Did Cole fuck you good?"

"He did," she gasped, her face showed shock. Her Max coming on strong, surprising her, surprising himself. He knew her better than Cole. "Did my best friend's cock fill up your tight little pussy?"

"It did..."

"Yeah, you looked like you loved every inch, you dirty slut."

"Oh shit, Max..."

"Dirty Maggie," he growled in her ear and grabbed a handful of her silky hair. He walked on his knees around behind her, nudged her legs wider with his knee then lined himself up. Her back rose and fell with her desperate breaths.

"This what you wanted him to do? This what you wanted from Cole tonight?" He slammed himself into her in one hard stroke. Her ass smacked against his hips with a wet slap. Her cheeks jiggled and his cock flexed inside her. She cried out high and sharp. She was so wet and sloppy he barely felt her until she tightened up on him and her body gripped at him. "Squeeze it, slut. Squeeze that cock. You wish it was Cole's?"

"Yeah," she cried.

"You love his big cock?"

"I love it, Max..."

He pounded into her until he had her lowered on the bed. His mouth struggled close to her ear, so driven with filthy awful things he wanted to curse her with. "You little slut...you love cock...tell me you love it..."

"Ah, I love cock..."

"You dirty whore, you're filth..."

"Ah!" she cried, and she whipped her hair around, thrust her hips, eagerly wanting his cock, trying to fuck him back. "God Max, he fucked me so good, he's bigger than you, better than you, God he makes me come..."

"No good, Maggie, you're no good. You're so much better than this...why you want to be one of those girls? ...Why you want to be a fucking whore?"

She let out a long low wailing sound that frightened him at first and his instinct was to let her up and hold her. It sounded like a mourning. “That’s all you are? That’s all you want to be? ...A hole for men to stick their big cocks in? ...”

She moaned *God, God, God*, over and over and dug her forehead into the mattress. Then a groaning mantra came from the sheets in pace with his thrusts. *Harder*. She wanted it harder.

He couldn’t think, couldn’t talk, couldn’t come up with any more dirty mind games, his own mind was lost in a filthy fugue. He pummeled her. Her bed rattled, and he realized how hot and sweaty it had become in her room. Her sex made wet slushing sounds, they both panted like they were at the end of a marathon. And in a way they were. He gripped her waist hard and fucked her like he hated her, like he was trying to hurt her. She loved it, she took it. She grunted and cried and clamored, and finally she said, *I’m coming, oh I’m coming*. She yelled it. Yelled it loud and vigorous. Way louder than she’d ever been. It was a pronouncement that would have been heard by anyone in the hall. That excited him. He wanted everyone on this floor to know he was Maggie’s boss, that he made her come, that he had the power.

“Make me come, Max,” she yelled, followed by shrieks and cries that were wonderful and at the same time a little worrying. It sounded like she was being victimized, and it shook him, slowed his stroke. Her hands bunched sheets and they gripped them so tightly her arms shook. She wheezed, “Harder...ah, deeper...” and he tried to resume. Sweat dripped from his nose and he looked at her gleaming ass, shining with spread excitement and sweat. He gave it to her. Hard sharp thrusts that smacked his hip bones against her cheeks and sent a tremble through her flesh. She came and came and it was her sounds that brought it out of him. They came at the same time and his heart surged with joy that they could share this. Two lovers been together a long time. He was learning. Other men were teaching him about his wife-to-be and he wanted to learn everything he could from those dirty detectives.

HER CHEST HEAVED in and out. Her mouth was full of sheets or something cotton. Her hair clung to her face. What Cole had started Max had finished.

Her future husband slipped his cock out of her and bounced in the bed next to her. Max was as out of breath as she was. Her hand came up, fingers clawing the bedding out of her mouth, clearing her airway. She coughed. Her eardrums rang. She rolled against her Maxy, his hot skin pressed to her hot skin. They were both wet with a sheen of beaded sweat. She cuddled him, put her ear in his armpit and kissed his nipple, her hand lay over his belly, his still-hard cock pointing up and to the side, glistening wet with semen and what she'd produced from her insides. His chest rose up and down in double time, and the tremor of his rampant heartbeat shook his skin.

He gulped air, struggling to say something, finally gasped, "Holy shit...oh my God...was that...fucking great or what?"

"That was fucking great," she gulped as well. And it was. Max hit all her spots. Physically and mentally, and having sex with him wiped the slate clear in a way. All the badness, all the wrong and improper things that she and their best friend had done tonight when they were alone were now underwater (or under a wave of Max's semen at least). Max was her lover, Max was her mate. Cole was just fun. Having wild and passionate sex with Max put things in their proper alignment. However, laying now with her ear on her Max's body, hearing his ghostly wind, she was haunted by two

thoughts. The things he'd said to her, and the things she said to herself. Secret things, dark ideas that when conjured tickled her in such a strange way she was drawn to them, pulled to them like a bearing to a magnet.

"Max?"

"Maggie?" he whispered, and she felt him kiss the crown of her head. He gripped her arm and held her to him.

"You don't think...those things you said...you don't really think I'm a slut? ..."

"Of course not, Maggie. It's just...dirty talk...you know..."

"Okay," she said. But while it was dirty talk to him there was something in those words that excited her and ruined her. It made her base and low and she was so frightened to be that, yet when she was named *slut* it turned her on.

"Baby," he called, and he was half laughing, taking her chin and tilting it up so he could look in her eyes. "How could you think I really think that?"

"Well, I am, in a way..."

"No, you're not, Maggie..."

"Okay," she said.

He kept his smirk, a look of concern in his eyes, but he kissed her. Pressed his lips to hers fully and held them together. She ran her nails over his chest.

"Are you a slut?" he asked her when he pulled his lips from hers. "I mean...do you want me to say that anymore?"

She felt herself blush a little, felt a heat rise to her cheeks. "Yeah," she said. "I don't know why, but I like it."

"That's okay. I don't know why, but I like it when you say Cole is better than me."

She cuddled closer to him, got as close as she could, pressing her thighs to him even. She kissed his nipple again, said, "I like saying that to you."

For whatever the reason, she found that sweet and endearing. For so long she'd thought of her Max as being sexually superior. When she met him she was practically a virgin. She'd had bad and clumsy sex one time, and one time only. Max was handsome and funny and cool, and he had no problems getting girls. He was dating when she met him. She was so foreign to that world, so frightened by it. It was nice to know he had his own set of hang-ups.

He said, "You like saying those things? ...You're so dirty."

"Turns out I am."

Max sighed, said, "God, that was incredible. You know—I wasn't even in the mood? ..."

"You weren't?"

He laughed. "Uh...no..."

"Hard to believe..."

Max said with hesitation, "I just...I don't know...thought about you...with Cole...and I got so mad, but so..."

She was listening and biting her lip. She whispered, "Horny?" Then resumed chewing the inside of her mouth.

"Yeah...so horny...crazy..."

Her mouth worked around, her brow lowered. She felt a rising guilt but it was at sword points with her second haunting thought.

There was enormous excitement in cheating.

When she saw Max in the hall outside her dorm room she was so happy...then, she was consumed by the terrible things she'd done tonight. Her smile and warmth had been honest but every step closer Max came she was set on fire with her duplicity. The flames rose up from between her legs, like a wildfire, ate up her insides until by the time she kissed Max she'd been completely immolated. Maybe that was why she shaved her pubic hair off. Some sort of swailing to prevent the fire's spread. A controlled, prescribed burn...

"What's so funny?" he asked her as she gently shook against him.

She wiped an errant beaded tear from her lower lid and giggled. "Me," she said. "I'm funny."

"Hey," he said, taking her chin again and making her look at him. He kissed her lips. "I love you so much."

"Max, I love you too," she said.

And she did. That was what made her awful indiscretion so exciting. She cared what he thought. She didn't want to hurt him. But she wanted Cole. She wanted him so bad. She'd wanted to make love with Cole tonight (no, fuck, Maggie, you wanted to fuck Cole) that she was left unfulfilled and aching. By not *fucking* him, she had created an illness in her body. She needed him.

Then, confronted by innocent Max, it was like his love was a mirror and it was reflecting her lugubrious hidden truth back at her. And while she was

horrified by the image, she was also driven wild by it. In that image she was naked, Cole was naked, and their heaving bodies banged against one another and her hair tangled, and her nails raked...

When Max wanted to go down on her, she panicked. He would smell the Vaseline. He would smell Cole. Her man would smell another man. Her infidelity would be discovered. And while she was relatively blameless, the notion that she would have another man's smell on her and it would have to be kept hidden was...exciting. And what if he were to remove her top? Would he see the frosted glaze on her chest? ...The shine of another man's sexual product. The notion, even now, had an intoxicating air. The fear of being discovered was so thrilling, so intense, that sex with Max had given her a screaming orgasm.

"I'M OKAY, you know? I mean, *we're* okay..."

Max said, "We are?"

She looked up to his eyes and wiggled herself against him. "I mean it. I really do love you. This wouldn't be as much fun without you."

"As much fun," he said worriedly.

"You know what I mean."

"It sounds like it would be something you would do without me..."

"Have sex with other men? If you and I weren't together? Yeah, I would, Max. And it would be fun."

He groaned quietly but painfully and his eyes narrowed with a frown.

"What?" she said. "I'm saying I like having you with me..." She ran her hand around his belly button in clockwise circles.

"Maggie... Did you really not...did you have sex with Cole tonight?"

"Wait... What we did at my house was incredible, Max. I love that we're doing this together, I love that we're doing it with Cole too."

His hand moved to her shoulder and he held her. "You were alone with him tonight..."

They held each other's gaze and she kept her expression even. There was a yearning there in his eyes, and she could sense it in the tension in his grip on her shoulder. She broke away, lowered her eyes to consider him.

"Someone's getting aroused," she whispered. Max had grown hard again. Hadn't even managed to go down really but his renewed swelling

was evident. His cock poked out straight and true and red and pulsing. He was completely, fully and gloriously erect. Her badness aroused him. She did this to him.

She put a fingertip on his hole and pressed down. His stiffness was striking. Max watched her hand work, watched her test his magnificent hardness, watched her explore her man with just the point of her finger. She went around his corona and he groaned. She tickled it under its narrow chin. Down his cable, his corpus spongiosum, then over his tight scrotum, scrutinizing the shape of his testicles in their sticky hairy bag.

“Did you do something or not, Maggie?”

“Your hard little cock tells me you wanted me to.”

“It’s not little, Maggie, come on...”

She shrugged, looked in his eyes, saw she had his complete attention. “Compared to my other men, you’re small.”

His mouth worked around. His expression didn’t grow in anger; if anything, it softened. Attuned to her words, seemingly eager for more, his eyes stayed on hers.

“You’ve seen both my lovers. Their cocks are magnificent.”

He bit his lip. She wrapped her grip on his aching hardness and watched his eyes narrow. He was steely, hot; its pulse fluttered in her hand. She stroked him.

His hand pushed her shoulder and he held her gently, getting her attention and looking in her eyes.

“Maggie, honestly... Did you do something?”

“You tell me, Maxy. You’re my lover, you’re my man...you tell me. Look in my eyes and tell me what you see.”

He stared into her while she slowly jerked his cock, giving him a light and caring grip. After a while, he said weakly, “I don’t know, Maggie. Just tell me...”

“You tell me. If it’s not in my eyes, maybe it’s somewhere else...”

“What do you mean?” he said, his eyebrows going up in the middle.

She said with a smile, “You think I did something? You think I’m that kind of girl? ...Launch an investigation.”

He snorted breath through his nose, his smile uncertain, his brow lowered now, eyeing her suspiciously. They lay face to face, sharing a pillow, Max’s hips thrust out to her so she could get a good grip on his erection.

“When you texted me...”

“Yeah?” She stroked gently.

“I saw you. You weren’t in the North quad. You said you were.”

“Uh-oh,” she said, a cocky grin on her lips, performing for him, attuning to him, gaging her lover through his beautiful eyes and the hardness in her hand. A feeling of guilt washed up but she didn’t hate it. His cock told her she didn’t need to hate it. She was being careful with him, walking carefully through his sexual minefield. She wanted to caress his hurt not wield it like a weapon.

“What do you mean *Uh-oh*? ...What does that mean?”

“Don’t stop...look in my eyes, Max.”

“Did you...you lied. You were with Cole...”

“You knew I was with Cole.”

“You were *with* him.”

“I told you I wasn’t *with* him.”

“Then what are you saying?”

“I’m not saying anything. You’re doing all the talking. What do you think I did?”

“You fucked him.”

“I told you I didn’t.”

“Sucked him?” His voice was tight and worried. Had she sucked him again? He’d sat mutely on her beach last weekend and did nothing to prevent her from sucking their Best Man’s cock. He wanted it to happen, but he hated himself for it.

His cock went slick and she looked down to see it shining wetly again, pumping out a flux of clear lubricating excitement, her poor boy’s distress somehow deeply connected with his sexuality. He was handsome and he was smart and she loved him but something in him was excited by her badness and a certain slippery fear that he seemed to crave.

“I wanted to, but no...”

“Why did you text me...and say...”

“I’m a liar.”

“Why?”

“You’ll never know.”

“Come on Maggie, seriously...”

“We were planning a surprise party...”

“It’s not funny...”

“Tell me, Max... Tell me your worst fear. I want to know what the worst thing is...”

“I don’t know...” he murmured, but she saw in those eyes that he *did* know. She also saw that he would tell her. That dark shadow in him wanted her to know. It was a little timid, but if she rubbed his slippery cock a little she could get it to spill the beans.

“Tell me, Max...tell me... What were you afraid we were doing...fucking? ...Worse? Tell me your fears, Maxy...”

“Fucking...leaving me out...laughing at me behind my back. Lying to me...”

“Am I lying?”

“You lied about where you were...”

“Was I...*bad*?”

“Were you?”

She let her hand off him. His cock wagged stiffly, glistening with his precum.

“Was I bad, Max?” she said, emphasizing her words to him, looking fiercely in his eyes as she rolled away and lay on her back and drew her knees up.

He watched her with befuddlement. He looked up and down her body and she tingled with anticipation... *She could be discovered. Her bad secrets could be revealed!* She writhed in the sheets. Max pursed his lips and chewed the inside of his mouth. He raised up on an elbow and her heart began to race.

His hand rested across her bare leg, curling lightly over and his fingertips pressing in the sensitive flesh of her inner thigh. A cat-like groan escaped her and it was a surprise. Her legs worked up and down, her bare soles sliding along the sheets while he handled her so close to her sex. She watched his face and he was still stricken with puzzlement but she kept his eye and wanted him to understand.

“Were you...bad?”

She sucked her lips into her mouth as he sat up. Got to his knees then and she clamped her thighs together. He walked himself to her feet and he rested his grip on her two knees.

“Were you bad, Margaret?”

“Only Cole calls me Margaret, okay?” His features fell, the tension gone, the energy gone, his face looked deflated.

“Why?” he said.

“I like it when he says it. I’m your Maggie. Look at me...I’m your Maggie.”

His mouth forced a grim resolved line and he spread her legs wide.

“Oh, Max,” she sighed, feeling the rush of her cool dorm room air touch all her hot wet flesh. She was exposed to him, her bare sex, shaved and spread. His eyes were fixed on her, his gaze looking directly on her pink slash. She flexed all her muscles, her hips and glutes flexing and releasing, an enormous...what? Itch? Something building inside her...a profound desire.

She whispered, “Kiss it.”

His eyes kept their stare. “It’s a mess.”

She giggled, softly, breathy. “What does it look like?”

“A pink oyster, twisted...it’s leaking...”

“Yeah?” she sighed, high and desperate. “Is it your come?”

His eyes went to hers now, a slight attitude of worry passing his face. “Is that my come?”

She whispered, “Taste it.”

A tremor passed his jaw, his eyes stayed on hers, but his body began to slump down the bed, his face gradually coming between her legs. He kissed the inside of her thigh and got her quivering. Her hands went down to encourage him, weaving fingers through his hair and running her nails over his scalp. When his lips touched her sex it was like a thump in her belly. It heaved and trembled. His mouth was hot and wet and he made love to her sex. Parting her lips, kissing and running his tongue over her, where she’d been dirtied, not caring if the semen leaking from her might be mixed with his best friend’s. So turned on right now, turned on by her, that he would put his mouth to her defilement.

“That’s it, baby,” she cooed. His pace was slow and loving and she ground into him purposefully, syncopating with his movement and his pressure to find the perfect, most thrilling feel to her sopping wet pussy.

She got his attention, put her hands on his cheeks and held his face, his ears between her fingers—when his eyes met hers she said, “Is that *your* come?”

His wet eyes trembled, holding her gaze, he said, “I don’t know.”

“Come here.”

She guided him to her mouth and he came up, got on all fours over her, his body heat warming her, his hot hard cock slipping across her flesh. She kissed him. Held his face steady in her hands and locked her mouth on his. He kissed her hungrily and she met it with eager desire. Their mouths twisted and sucked and after a long while, where she sucked all the wet from him, she pulled back and said, "That's your come. That's my Max's come. Cole's tastes different."

"Oh fuck...oh Maggie..." he said and he looked on the verge of going wild.

"I'm bad." She grinned for him.

"You're so fucking bad," he gasped. "Why won't you take your top off?"

"Don't make me..."

"What are you hiding?" he said, rearing up and slipping his hands up her shirt, his warm loving hands coming up to her bra. He explored her breasts, watching her, concerned. He assumed he'd find her without a bra but she was wearing one. She smiled. Hooked his thumbs under the hem of her sweater then, under her shirt, and he peeled them up, slowly revealed her stomach. He kissed her, his eyes on hers. Now he was kissing where Cole had spurted his semen. All over her belly, all up her chest. Max kissed higher, running his tongue around and through her tight little belly button. She caressed his face. He worked higher, licking and suckling.

"What did you do with him?" he whispered to her.

"You tell me..."

"Maggie, stop it..."

"Do you taste him on my belly?"

"What do you mean?"

"I didn't cheat." Her hand slipped down his bare stomach, watched his face while her hand slid so slow along his tummy, gripped his cock again, renewed her stroking. His head slumped forward. "You're so hard, Max. You love your bad girl..."

"I love you."

"I love you too." She slipped her hand up and down him, producing more precum from him, feeling her own wetness rising. "What if I did this for Cole?"

"Jerk him off?" he groaned, his eyes worried but so narrowed they were almost closed.

She licked her lips, said, "What if he came all over my stomach and you were kissing me there?"

"Did you?" he whined.

"Picture it, picture it for me, Max," she said, her stroke feathering him at his tip.

"Maggie, p-please tell me...did you jerk Cole off..."

"I didn't cheat, I told you. Maybe I used my hands...that's not *really* cheating..."

"Mm, you made him come?"

"Yeah, I might have. Not inside me, Max...but I couldn't keep my hands off your best friend."

His legs began to writhe. "Did he make you come?"

"Yeah, maybe. He makes me come so hard..."

His eyes sparked now, narrow but intense. "How? Maggie, how did he make you come?"

She whispered, "That's private..."

"Private?"

"I don't want to say."

"Why not?"

"You like your bad Maggie, or not?"

"I don't know."

"Maybe we played around a little, maybe we made out, Max. I was as good as I can be but you know how hot your best friend is. You know how good looking he is..."

"Yeah..."

"Maybe we just played with each other. Maybe we tried to be good...we love you so much Max but we can't keep our hands off each other..."

"Did you?"

"Maybe, Max...it's a secret..."

He stared into her, his expression in a purgatory between pain and pleasure. Part of him horrified at what his girl did behind his back, the other part of him excitingly evident in her soft grip. Max was hard as he could be, harder than she'd ever felt him, she was sure. He was endlessly streaming his precum. She had him trembling and stupefied. His lips trembled.

"Where's that smile, Maxy? ...Show me that smile...we're having fun..."

His mouth opened to say something, but he only croaked.

She slowed her luxurious stroking, said, "If you don't smile, I'll stop."

He forced his lips to a line that crawled into an uneasy and artificial smile.

“You want this, don’t you?”

“Yeah...”

“Do you?” she said again, resuming a full and fast stroke on his shaft, down into his pubic hair, making his balls jiggle.

“Mm, ah, fuck I do,” he gasped.

She slowed again, whispered, “Kiss me.”

Their lips came together and she felt in his soft pouting union a devotion to her. She had what he needed.

“Max, maybe once Cole and I were kissing...maybe he took his cock out...”

He moaned and his kiss broke, his forehead pressing to hers. His hips gently thrust against her stroke.

“And when his cock was out...I couldn’t *not* put my hand on it...”

“You couldn’t?”

Her other hand came to his scrotum, gripped his balls and squeezed them carefully. “He’s so hot, Max. His body, his face...God, his big cock...”

“You did it without me?” he gasped.

“I can’t help it, Max. I’m such a slut.”

“You are...”

“You told me.”

“You are a slut.”

“That’s it,” she whispered, her fist pumping him with a feathery grip. She kissed his lips, said, “You love your little slut...”

“I do. I fucking do.”

She said, “You should keep your eye on her.”

“I-I...should?”

“She’s so bad. So hungry. So horny. I wonder what she’s going to do.”

“Whats sh-she going to do?”

“She’s going to be bad. Make sure you watch her. She can’t be trusted.”

Max’s hand came up and he pushed her bunched shirt and sweater higher, hooked a thumb underneath and formed a V, hoisting it above her breast bone.

“That’s it, Maxy, you want to come on my tummy?”

“Yeah,” he gasped.

“You want to come where Cole came?”

“Did he...did he...come on you?”

“I stroked that fat cock of his like this and I watched it in my hand, Max, watched his foreskin, watched that big cock head ripple in my fist, Max, he has such a big sexy cock...”

He sobbed and bucked, thrust his hips, drove his cock in and out of her wet hand. She gripped his balls tightly.

“Kiss me, Max, kiss me where he came on me, kiss my chest.

He hunched, crying and sweating, groaning. Her hand pumped him furiously and he leaked over her knuckles. His mouth sucked on her clumsily, he snorted breath through his nose in heaves and starts and for a brief moment she felt pity for him. She felt she had taken him too far. His cock was like an iron column, his arousal complete, but he cried tears on to her skin.

She kissed the top of his head, stroked him faster, whispered to him, “We don’t laugh at you. We love you. We both love you so much, baby...”

His hand clutched at her shoulders, his fingertips dug deeply into her, hurting her, bruising her bones. He chugged and jumped, a creak, long and low came from him as his body went tense and immobile. Her belly was abruptly spattered with his hot seed and her grip on him went liquid. She stroked him lovingly and felt his endless cascade on her skin.

“That’s it baby, give me your come, baby. Cole and I love you, Maxy, that’s it...”

She let his balls go, rubbed his back, and he buried his face in the crook of her neck. Still he came, pulsing jets weakening to pattering spurts. Soon she slowed and she held him in her hand, her stroking turning to a caress, easing eventually to cradling. He breathed and heaved, his sobs abated and he held her.

Epilogue

HIS HEAD POUNDED FIERCELY. She'd given him an orgasm like no other he'd ever had. He felt sheets of shame wash over him. Shame and love and fear and ecstasy. He was over her on all fours, his head buried in her neck, her hand soothing his back, her other one gently holding his fading erection. Her hand on him cold and wet from his semen. She stayed with him, held him while he recovered.

She'd coaxed from him the silt that congregated in the darkest corners of his mind. The dirt and filth that secretly accumulated in the creases of his every day life. She wanted them, wanted to see them, did it with love and care and she shared with him his shame and didn't judge him for it. He felt emptied and each beat of his heart, held in the arms of the woman he loved, brought him out of his darkness, brought him into the light, made him feel accepted and cared for. While he'd embarrassed himself to her, revealed to her his weakness, his fear, emasculated himself, he felt wondrously accepted. He breathed, a smile came to him. He'd been emptied of the black. She'd pulled it from him, cleaned out all those dark seams. He laughed.

She laughed now too, her hand soothing his back again. Her touch was magnificent and loving. And as he sighed into her he was suddenly aware that while she had emptied him, cleaned out his filth, he couldn't wait for it to accumulate again and have her purge him all over. Get himself dirty so she could keep him sanitized.

He emerged from the warm cave, the hollow of her neck, his mouth traveled her jaw and he found her lips with his own; kissed her. Held her face in his hands and she rested her cold semen hands on the crease of his hips. When he broke from her he looked in her eyes. There was nothing he could say, a connection to her he felt that was so profound his words would be clumsy. They smiled together.

She head-butted his chin gently, tapped him three times, whispered, "Okay, get off me."

He fell next to her side, lay on his back and she sat up slowly, her tummy hunched, streaming with his white evidence. Her hands were in her lap, formed in wet claws.

She said, "You want to know what I did with Cole, but I'm not going to tell you."

"Why not?"

"I want to have my secrets."

He exhaled til he was empty, pushed all the air out of his body while he thought about the things she might do behind his back. "Secrets...from me?"

He could feel her shrug as she sat next to him. She said, "They're there to discover, but you're not going to hear it from me." She got to her knees, walked on them and her elbows, her hands curled like wet spiders. There was a T-shirt on her dresser, clean and neatly folded but she yanked it down and ran her hands through it. Her ass was up in the air, her glistening labia exposed to him. She was bare below her waist except for long rainbow striped socks that came just below her knee. He rubbed a thumb over her heel, and she flinched and he smiled seeing her labia wink at him. He slapped her ass cheek lovingly.

There were things, he imagined, that his girl wanted from this. Things she wanted to experience with other men. He'd sent her on this path to suit his own whim and fantasy but she had a brain and a heart all her own. It was her curiosity that brought them to where they were now. Her curiosity was a healthy thing. He said, "Like Maggie and her figure model?"

He was aware now of her head slowly rotating to face him over her shoulder. She said, "What do you mean?"

"You know...you told me...you touched him..."

"Oh..."

"Did you do more than that?"

"No...not behind your back. You saw it all. I miss him, you know?"

“Miss Jay?”

She nodded without looking his way. Then she was climbing the bed, back to him on all fours. She lay by his side and put her chin on his arm.

He said, “We have Cole...”

She said, “Doesn’t mean I don’t think about Jay.”

“Do you?” he said, suppressing a whine that wanted to accelerate his voice through restricted passages.

She held up his hand in both of hers. She took her left hand and ran her fingers between his, piggy-backing it. Her engagement ring sparkled in the light.

He’d bought her that ring last Christmas when he knew he would propose. There was no other girl for him ever. He knew it the way you knew things in your life were absolutes. Knew it like he knew he needed air to breathe and light to see. So last Christmas, home in Michigan to stay with his family for the Holidays, he made his intentions known to his mother, father, and siblings. There was no dissension. Who wouldn’t love little beautiful, smart and funny Maggie Becker? His Dad had a Dad-crush on her. His mother doted on her. His brothers... Well, they’d even admitted dirty thoughts about her, though he suspected they were fictional, just trying to rile him. They thought she was *the one* too. So he went with his brothers down to the jeweler and bought her this symbol of his devotion.

Maggie broke his reverie, whispered, “Whatever happened in Cole’s room, Max, you don’t have to worry. We would never laugh at you.”

“You’re going away...”

“I am.”

“I don’t know if I can be without you right now. You’re gone the whole weekend. The holiday weekend.”

“To buy a wedding dress...for our wedding...”

“It’s going to kill me to not be near you. I need you...”

“Four whole days, Maxy...”

“He turned and held her cheek. “Maggie, I’m going to think about you every minute.”

“Can you trust me? ...”

“Yes. Can’t I? ...”

“I’m a liar.”

He joked, “What are you going to do. Go home and fuck Lee?” He ran his thumb over her beautiful cheekbone.

“He’s not the only guy I know in Rhode Island.”

His features slumped. “Don’t.”

“You never know, Max.”

He kissed her forehead sweetly.

She smiled and it wasn’t malicious or mean, not even sly. It was endearing and kind. She said, “If I were you I wouldn’t trust me one bit.”

Afterword

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